

After Action Review

UNDP's Response to the Yemen Crisis

(August 2015 – March 2016)



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Executive Summary

Introduction

At the end of 2011, after a year of mass public demonstrations and armed opposition, Yemen embarked on an ambitious political transition that many believed would serve as a positive example of the ‘Arab Spring’ movements in the Middle East. Following the conclusion of an all-inclusive National Dialogue process in 2014, however, the country’s fragile stability progressively deteriorated, with clashes between the Houthis and Sunni tribes leading to armed confrontations with the government and the eventual take-over of the government by the Houthis. This resulted in the escalation of the conflict into a full-scale war in March 2015 which, despite numerous ceasefire and mediation attempts, has not been resolved to this day.

The impact of the conflict has been devastating. Between March 2015 and February 2016, approximately 3,000 civilians were estimated to have been killed, with over 12,000 injured. The conflict exacerbated an already dire economic and social situation, which in the years following the 2011 crisis had been marked by continued decline of economic growth, rising unemployment and inequality, increasing prices for basic commodities, and the deterioration of state institutional capacities, including provision of core social services, local government and fiscal sustainability.

Following a brief suspension of UN operations and evacuation of international staff in March 2015, the organization resumed its operations shortly thereafter, with a focus on diplomatic mediation through the Office of the Special Envoy, and emergency humanitarian assistance. With the IASC declaration of a level 3 emergency in July 2015, these efforts focused primarily on life-saving emergency assistance, targeting populations and regions most affected by the conflict.

The March 2015 crisis had a significant impact on UNDP’s role and capacities in Yemen, necessitating a wholesale reorientation of programme focus from supporting transitional governance to immediate crisis-related recovery and livelihoods priorities. The crisis led to a prolonged evacuation and relocation of staff, and created an extremely challenging operating environment. Through UNDP’s crisis response mechanism, activated from March onwards, significant support and resources were provided to the CO to reorient its programmatic efforts, strengthen CO capacities, and position UNDP within the broader UN system.

This After Action Review focuses on the design and management of the UNDP response to the crisis in Yemen, with specific focus on the period August 2015 – March 2016, with a view to identifying lessons learned for future crisis response engagements. Key elements of the response reviewed include: UNDPs corporate and country level programmatic and operational response; UN and interagency coordination; contribution to Disaster Needs Assessment (DNA) and recovery processes; and communications and resource mobilization.

Analysis of the Response

The crisis situation of March 2015 was characterized by both its slow-onset and protracted nature. The events of March 2015 marked a significant and extremely violent escalation of an existing crisis that had been deepening since late 2014. While its impact could not have been foreseen, it did not constitute a surprise, given the steady deterioration of the situation since late 2014. The second feature of the crisis was its protracted nature, marked by continued violence and insecurity, leading to a prolonged emergency response and predominantly humanitarian focus on life-saving assistance.

The nature of this crisis had several important implications for UNDP’s response, as framed by the Crisis Response SOPs. While noting applicability in slow-onset and protracted crises, the SOPs are primarily

structured to enable a corporate response to a sudden crisis or disaster. This had two main implications for how the corporate response was developed and implemented in Yemen, which together make a case for further reflection on how the SOPs could integrate specific provisions for triggering, planning and implementing responses in the context of crises such as Yemen's:

- **First, the L2 corporate response was only triggered after the crisis escalated significantly in March 2015.** In the months leading up to March 2015 several corporate crisis response options could have been considered, including an earlier triggering of the L2 or L3 phases, or a more concerted corporate focus and engagement during this phase to strengthen preparedness, implement early warning activities, undertake contingency planning, and initiate pre-planning of support—prior to the formal activation of the corporate response.
- **Second, the Level 3 response focused on a strong temporary boost of expertise and resources, but did not adequately take into account the challenges to repositioning UNDP in the longer term.** The protracted nature of the crisis meant that key conditions enabling UNDP engagement on recovery normally present in a 'post-crisis' context were either absent, delayed or complicated. Developing and implementing a UNDP recovery approach in this context was extremely challenging, requiring a more sustained and longer-term approach. While the SURGE deployment provided essential support to the CO, and in many ways laid the foundation for developments on programming, operations and RM that occurred in late 2016, the foregoing points to the importance of considering a more staggered or phased approach to SURGE support in protracted crisis situation that is calibrated to an analysis of the operational environment and realistic timelines for responding.

The case of Yemen also highlights the importance of corporate engagement in ensuring a strategic and integrated approach to positioning UNDP at the intersection of humanitarian, peace and development efforts. The predominantly life-saving focus on humanitarian assistance following the March 2015 crisis, and the institutional dysfunctionalities created by the split in the RC and HC functions, created significant challenges in generating momentum on early recovery and resilience priorities, positioning UNDP and mobilizing needed resources. With hindsight, a stronger and more forceful corporate oversight on these issues was likely warranted, as well as a more strategic effort to integrate programme development, resource mobilization, inter-agency coordination and communications around the dual objectives of a) promoting dialogue and partnerships on recovery priorities; and b) articulating and positioning UNDP's programmatic strategy as part of a broader vision and consensus.

Planning of SURGE support in the context of a severe and prolonged crisis warrants careful planning and consultation. Although the urgency of crisis situations requires swift action, the 'rush to deployment' can in certain cases be counter-productive if not carefully planned and adequately consulted. In Yemen, the large SURGE team deployed during the latter half of 2015 faced important challenges which constrained its overall effectiveness. With UNDP in-country presence limited due to insecurity, most of the SURGE team was obliged to support the CO remotely from Amman, severely limiting its ability to interact and collaborate effectively with CO staff, and develop sufficiently contextualized advice and support. Some SURGE functions, terms of reference and advisor profiles were not adequately consulted before deployment, leading to confusion and lack of clarity. Finally, little flexibility was demonstrated in considering modalities other than the deployment of international advisors, which might have been more effective given the constraint (for instance provision of seed funding for pilot initiatives and recruitment of national experts and service providers). In contexts of slow-onset and protracted crises there is some latitude for a more detailed SURGE planning process, including more in-depth assessment of priority needs, definition of modalities for support tailored to the operational environment, and a properly structured process of consultation with stakeholders at HQ, regional and CO levels.

A related point is the linkage between SURGE support and other corporate change management and support functions. In the context of slow-onset and protracted crises – and particularly in cases where CO capacities are insufficient – SURGE support should not be considered a substitute for deeper 'root and branch' strengthening. SURGE support is –and should remain – focused on immediate response priorities and support,

with the aim of rapidly providing expertise, resources and capacity to enable UNDP to scale its capacity and strategically reposition itself in a crisis situation. At the same time, this cannot be sustained in the absence of broader organizational change and strengthening, particularly in contexts such as Yemen, where every part of the CO's capacity was affected by the crisis and had to be substantially refocused and retooled. Key to ensuring an effective and sustainable response lies in linking SURGE response to other corporate support functions and processes within the broader umbrella of the crisis response – and preferably as part of an integral strategy developed and overseen by the CB.

The case of Yemen also illustrates a number of challenges and trade-offs inherent in developing an appropriate programmatic response. The scale of the crisis in 2015 drastically and fundamentally altered the situation in the country, and necessitated a wholesale re-orientation of UNDP's country programme. Re-engineering an active country programme portfolio is an immensely challenging task, and in the context of Yemen this necessitated developing an overall strategy early on in the crisis response (framed as either an 'interim' CPD or amendment to an existing CPD) predicated on recovery priorities and approaches deemed relevant and feasible in the prevailing context, and against which UNDP could bring to bear demonstrated comparative advantages. Such a strategy (even in most basic form) would provide the framework for revising existing projects and developing new ones. Integrating programme portfolio review and development within a single programme strategy, and using that framework as UNDP's entry point in dialogue with other partners and donors on responding to the Yemen crisis, is arguably the way UNDP should have sought to position itself and engage with donors on both mobilization of new funds and reprogramming of existing resources.

Two significant opportunities were missed that could have led to a more effective programme response. The first, simply put, is that the Yemen Resilience Programme took far too long to be finalized – leaving UNDP without a clear (public) argument for a recovery approach and 'offer' to donors. Secondly, the process of developing the YRP and the review of the country programme portfolio were not adequately linked and were managed independently of each other, ultimately raising questions as to what exactly UNDP's country programme strategy was. Key lessons learned include a) the importance of rapidly developing a basic overall country programme strategy as early on as possible in the response (and not over-engineering it); and b) ensuring, through effective management, that programme strategy and portfolio review are fully integrated into a single process, ideally overseen by the SURGE Team Leader and DCD/P.

In the final instance, the CO and UNDP as a whole did benefit from the corporate crisis response. The corporate crisis structure demonstrated once again its value in providing a framework for communication, coordination and management across UNDP, and ensuring timely provision of advice and support to the CO. The SURGE assistance provided through the corporate response provided an array of critical services which in many respects provided critical capacity and expertise to the CO when it needed it the most (the challenging transition period following the 2015 crisis). Notable achievements in this regard include the development of a coherent programmatic vision and backbone for UNDP's engagement, development of RM systems and support for donor outreach, establishment of a strategic communications capacity within the CO, and provision of support in operations which provided the CO critical capacity and know-how in operating in crisis context. The impact of the SURGE and broader corporate crisis response were not immediately evident, but in many ways are considered to have laid the foundations for the increase in donor funding, partnerships and CO delivery that took place from mid-2016.

Summary of Key Findings and Lessons

The crisis response in Yemen points to several important overarching findings and lessons learned, which are analyzed in more detail in the subsequent sections :

1. The UNDP crisis response in Yemen demonstrates the strong relevance and importance of its corporate crisis response system in addressing complex and protracted crises, enabling corporate-wide attention and support, and guiding strategic decisions on UNDP's repositioning and reorientation;

2. While there is scope within the current crisis SOPs (2013) to address these types of crises, there is a need to develop specific provisions on corporate engagement and support during pre-crisis phases, as well as over longer time periods in protracted crises situations, with linkages to other corporate change management and support mechanisms to complement temporary surge support.
3. While speed is of the essence in developing corporate SURGE responses, the Yemen case highlights the critical importance of accurately assessing surge needs, ensuring adequate consultation and ownership by frontline units, and ensuring that the modalities of SURGE support are calibrated to maximize the use and effectiveness of resources.
4. The Yemen cause also highlights the importance of ensuring that appropriate senior management capacities are in place to lead the response and take necessary decisions in situations that are both extremely challenging and time-sensitive.
5. In Yemen, the experience of the YRP highlights the importance of striking the right balance between investment in overall strategy formulation and programme portfolio review and development. Early upfront agreement on UNDP strategic priorities is necessary to inform both portfolio re-alignment and development of new projects, and enable UNDP to engage pro-actively in strategic dialogue with donors and other international partners.
6. Despite being a protracted conflict, the Yemen case also demonstrates the importance of rapidly defining key aspects of the UNDP response (programmatic, advocacy, RM, etc), to enable early engagement and positioning of UNDP with national and international stakeholders. Corporate level crisis response structures (notably the CB) have an important role to ensure compliance of units involved in the response with decisions and in ensuring that critical recovery milestones are achieved in timely manner.
7. Where responding to a crisis entails a significant reorientation of UNDP country programmatic and operational capacities, as was the case in Yemen, an early capacity review should be undertaken to inform both SURGE support and longer-term change management processes.
8. The case of Yemen—where the predominant focus on life-saving humanitarian assistance initially marginalized development and peacebuilding efforts—highlights the importance of UNDP in playing a proactive role in both facilitating dialogue on recovery and resilience priorities, supporting effective coordination among UN and other partners on these issues, and clearly advocating for its role based on identified comparative advantages and programmatic strengths.

Recommendations

Corporate Crisis Response Mechanisms (Crisis Board, CSMT)

1. In situations of complex and protracted crises under level 2 and 3 responses, UNDP's crisis response mechanisms needs to be more adept at understanding the political context and flexible in adapting to fluid and unpredictable environments/situations, latitude for which is provided in both the current (2013) and draft crisis response SOPs (dated 2016).
2. UNDP's Crisis Response SOPs should provide clearer guidance on addressing 'pre-crisis' but clearly deteriorating situations ('slow-onset' crises), with options including earlier activation of the crisis response (under either L1 or L2 phases) or the formal inclusion of a pre-crisis phase. Pre-crisis response and support could include early warning analysis and monitoring, contingency and preparedness planning and positioning, 'crisis' focused change management support and programmatic/thematic advisory support, as well as engagement in inter-agency level contingency and crisis mechanisms.
3. On early warning, consideration should be given to some form of structured process for corporate monitoring of potential crisis situations (including possibly through the Executive Team or through an inter-agency process such as the SG's Regular Monthly Review (RMR) meetings). Such processes could

provide a mechanism for monitoring and triggering UNDP preventive actions at country level, which in turn could be financed through Trac 3.2 or other UNDP resources.

4. Criteria and timelines for triggering the L3 phase and SURGE support should be re-examined to accurately assess emergency response priorities and develop the corresponding SURGE plan. Where necessary, this could entail delinking UNDP L3 activation from the IASC L3 (which the SOPs already provide for), and/or contemplating a phased approach to SURGE planning beginning as early as possible (including pre-planning prior to formal L3 activation). Linkages to UN-wide monitoring mechanisms (including the Regular Monthly Review process) could also be useful in informing UNDP crisis response planning triggers.
5. In contexts of protracted crises, and/or situations where CO needs require a longer-term investment in terms of support, UNDP should consider options for either a) extending or phasing SURGE support to ensure sufficient 'spread' of expertise and resources required to achieve critical programme, operations and RM milestones; or b) linking provision of short-term SURGE support to a longer-term corporate process of change management. In the case of the former, consideration of an 'extended' or 'protracted L3' phase should be considered, with separate timelines and modalities for provision of support (which could be staggered or phased), including through other corporate mechanisms, over the duration of a protracted crisis.
6. In contexts of complex and major crises, a strategic corporate focus on programmatic, RM, operations and advocacy issues is essential, both to leverage the full breadth of corporate resources, positioning and relationships, and to ensure continuity of effort when country-level engagement alone on these issues is insufficient.
7. The roles and responsibilities of UNDP Regional Hubs and BPPS advisors co-located therein should be codified and institutionalized as part of the crisis response SOPs in the context of both L2 and L3 responses, and across the various phases of the SURGE response. RH expertise and experience should be integrated as much as possible in SURGE support, and appropriate coordination mechanisms established to maximize synergies.
8. When developing the SURGE assistance package, the full range of modalities as outlined in the corporate SOPs (2013 and draft 2016 versions) should be considered and discussed at the level of the CB and CMT, to ensure that the support provided is optimized to the needs and load-bearing capacity of the CO.
9. The development and implementation of the crisis response is by definition a corporate management tool, but should be founded on the principles of partnership and collaboration between the various entities involved, and in particular with COs. In this context, executive decision making should be balanced with adequate consultation and coordination to ensure consensus on strategy and tools, and appropriate sensitivity and adaptation to country realities.¹
10. In crisis situations where timely decisions, actions and results are of critical importance, the CB needs to exercise appropriate oversight over accountability and responsibility, and ensure compliance with decisions and timelines.

SURGE Deployment

1. In situations where the remote management and provision of SURGE support is necessary, adequate measures are required to ensure adequate interaction, coordination and integration between SURGE and CO teams. This includes prioritizing sufficient access to the country for SURGE advisors (and notably the Team Leader), negotiating additional staffing slots, oversight of cross-team collaboration by CO Senior Management, and ensuring that the CRT meets regularly using all available means.

¹ This is now reflected in the current draft of the UNDP Crisis Response SOPs (dated 2016), which place corporate support to the CO's at the "front and center" of the response.

2. Definition of SURGE functions, corresponding terms of reference, and identification/selection of advisors should be carefully planned and agreed between the CRU, Regional Bureaus, Central Bureaus, Regional Hub and the CO to ensure that deployments conform to needs, avoid duplication on staffing, and provide relevant expertise.
3. SURGE deployment timelines should take into account capacity of the CO to absorb and support staff and consultants, as well as the expected timelines for delivery of key crisis response outputs, with an emphasis on balancing the need for up-front capacity with making most effective use of SURGE resources in the overall process of CO reorientation and strengthening.
4. In order to facilitate the sustainability of SURGE functions following the end of SURGE support, SURGE teams should include handover and transition of functions as part of their responsibilities, and COs should be responsible for committing to measures and timelines for ensuring sustainability. These should be discussed and agreed by the CB prior to the conclusion of the SURGE mission, and monitored to ensure compliance, with additional support being provided as necessary (including through a linked change management and other corporate processes).

UNDP Country Office

1. In complex crises and emergencies, where the role of CO senior management is deemed critical, the review and assessment of CO management capacities, as foreseen in the Crisis Response SOPs, should be mandatory, in order to ensure an appropriate composition of skills and experience.
2. In contexts of slow onset and complex emergencies, crisis preparedness and contingency planning (covering both programme and operations) should be prioritized and undertaken either as an internal UNDP exercise or as part of a broader UN system efforts. Such planning should be mandatory for COs, and be utilized to also inform discussions at corporate level on possible crisis response approaches and modalities.
3. In contexts where CO's are confronted with unexpected and significant financial expenditures—either as a result of increased costs due to evacuation and security, or suspension of funds needed for core expenditures—some form of emergency corporate financing should be made available, perhaps on a reimbursable basis, to allow the CO to ensure its financial sustainability and provide 'space' for expenditure planning related to CO programmatic and operations reprofiling/reorientation.

Programmatic Response

1. In situations where a significant re-orientation of the country programme strategy is envisioned, or where there is uncertainty as to how needs and priorities could evolve, consideration should be given to development of a 'light' programme framework that can be adjusted over time, and emphasis placed on shorter-term interventions to respond to urgent needs and/or test new approaches.
2. Development of an overarching programme framework for crisis recovery should be balanced with the need to ensure rapid movement on design, financing and implementation of interventions in the short-term, including through the re-alignment of the existing programme portfolio. SURGE programme advisors should be fully integrated with the CO Programme team to ensure these processes are aligned. CRU Crisis Response Packages should constitute an essential part of the SURGE tool-kit in this respect.
3. SURGE support for programme development should be closely linked to CO advocacy, partnerships, RM and inter-agency efforts to facilitate a more strategic and comprehensive approach, and ensure that these different elements are mutual reinforcing.
4. In humanitarian contexts, UNDP programmatic support (including over the short-term) should build on a clear value proposition on UNDP's role in linking humanitarian and development needs, should be

grounded in a close analysis and understanding of country realities and context, and informed by the priorities/plans of other international partners and UNDP's comparative advantage.

Operational Response

1. As part of 'pre-crisis' corporate engagement and support, a rapid assessment of CO operational capacities should be undertaken to identify critical capacity gaps and provide a basis for identifying both SURGE support priorities and informing longer-term change management strategies.
2. SURGE supported provided as part of UNDP's crisis response should not be considered a substitute for a broader change management or capacity strengthening effort. In contexts where capacity needs are significant, SURGE support for operations should be complemented and linked to provision of additional corporate support organized through the regional bureau. This should ideally be assessed during the SURGE phase and included as part of SURGE transition and handover phase.
3. Re-orientation of CO programmes should be clearly delinked from staffing and contractual consideration. Staff on positions identified for termination should be supported as best as possible to allow them to transition with minimum disruption, including through temporary salary guarantees and corporately assisted placement in positions elsewhere in the organization.
4. On staffing more broadly, UNDP's crisis response SOPs should provide scenario-based guidance on how to address evacuation and reprofiling issues, which could help decrease potential delays and complications related to decision-making, and provide the basis for HR planning as part of a broader crisis response effort. These could also be integrated into business continuity planning.

UN and Inter-agency Coordination

1. At the onset of a complex crisis, and based on its situation assessment, UNDP should in future crises responses clearly highlight those early recovery, resilience and other developmental responses deemed critical as 'non-negotiable' based on IASC and WHS commitments, and be prepared to engage at the highest corporate level if necessary in this respect.
2. UNDP should explore multiple avenues to advocate, foster dialogue and secure consensus on recovery, resilience and other development priorities, including with the donor community, other development partners (including the World Bank and other IFIs), and national actors.
3. Within the UN system, UNDP should increase its support to the Resident Coordinator and inter-agency coordination mechanisms (including humanitarian cluster and recovery/development coordination fora) on recovery and resilience issues to facilitate evidence-based dialogue and consensus on UN system priorities and approaches.
4. UNDP should ensure robust engagement in both leading and contributing to Post-Disaster Needs Assessments (PDNAs) and Recovery and Peacebuilding Assessments (RPBAs), with a view to helping define a collective vision on recovery and development, build and strengthen partnerships with key development actors, and inform the positioning of UNDP's programme strategy.
5. With respect to future DNA-type exercises (now known as Recovery and Peacebuilding Assessments, or RPBAs) in contexts of protracted conflict and crisis, emphasis should also be placed on iterative exercises that can provide a dynamic framework for assessing and costing needs and priority interventions as the situation evolves.

Communication and Resource Mobilization

1. Communications and resource mobilization constitute core functions that should be as a priority sustained following a SURGE mission, given the longer-term time horizons of related processes.
2. In contexts where re-alignment of programmes and donor funding are necessary, this should be considered as an integral part of the resource mobilization strategy, with a focus on engaging donors on dialogue to support new programmatic directions through reprogrammed and new resources.
3. Clear responsibilities and accountability for resource mobilization efforts should be defined at both the CO level (including between SURGE team and the CO) and between Regional Bureaus and BERA at the level of the CB/CMT. Deadlines for key RM deliverables and associated products (programme strategies, project documents, etc.) should be set and agreed upfront, and compliance monitoring through the CB – particularly in time sensitive contexts.
4. CO resource mobilization efforts should be supported by the Regional Bureau and BERA in contexts where country level donor presence is limited, and maximize use of relationships and dialogue platforms at HQ and in donor capitals.
5. Engagement on RM issues should be mandatory at the level of corporate mechanisms, either through regular meetings of the CMST or through a dedicated Resource and Mobilization Task Force, in situations of significant resource mobilization challenges. Discussions in these mechanisms should be overseen by the CB which should be responsible for monitoring progress and providing appropriate guidance.
6. Building on recent developments in strengthening partnerships between UNDP and the World Bank, consideration should be given to how partnership efforts can be broadened to other IFIs, including notably the IsDB, KfW, EIB, among others, with an emphasis on co-leveraging UNDP's in-country experience and operational and technical capacities with financing available from the former.

Acronyms

AAR	After Action Review
BERA	Bureau for External Relations and Advocacy
BMS	Bureau of Management Support
BPPS	Bureau for Policy and Programme Support
CB	Crisis Board
CERF	UN Central Emergency Response Fund
CMST	Crisis Management Support Team
CO	Country Office
CPD	Country Programme Document
CRU	Crisis Response Unit
DNA	Damage and Needs Assessment
DPC	Direct project costs
DTF	Diplomatic Transit Facility
EIB	European Investment Bank
ER	Early recovery
ET	Executive Team
EU	European Union
GCC	Gulf Cooperation Council
HC	Humanitarian coordinator
HRP	Humanitarian Response Plan
IASC	Inter-Agency Standing Committee
IFI	International Financial Institution
IsDB	Islamic Development Bank
NGO	Non-governmental organization
OCHA	Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs
RBAS	Regional Bureau for Arab States
RC	Resident Coordinator
RM	Resource mobilization
RMR	Regular Monthly Review
RPBA	Recovery and Peacebuilding Assessment
RR	Resident Representative
SOPs	Standard Operating Procedures for Immediate Crisis Response
UNCT	UN Country Team
WB	World Bank
YRP	Yemen Resilience Programme

1. Introduction

1.1 Country/situation context

At the end of 2011, after a year of mass public demonstrations and armed opposition, Yemen embarked on an ambitious political transition that many believed would serve as a positive example of the ‘Arab Spring’ movements in the Middle East. Within the framework of a peace agreement brokered by the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), a unity government was formed, peaceful elections were held and an all-inclusive National Dialogue was organized between March 2013-January 2014 to address key political, social, and economic issues and pave the way for a constitutional drafting process. The Houthis, a Zaidi group with its origins in the northern Sa’dah governorate, along with other groups, refused to sign the National Dialogue Outcome Document.

The first half of 2014 was marked by clashes between the Houthis and Sunni tribes, which progressively spread across the country. In August, mass public protests broke out in Sana’a following the removal of fuel subsidies. The Houthis participated in these protests, which escalated into armed confrontations with the Yemen armed forces in September. Houthi forces emerged victorious from these clashes and occupied Sana’a, leading to a negotiated agreement to end the violence (the Peace and National Partnership Agreement) that entailed the resignation of the government, and tightened their control over state institutions. In January 2015, following their rejection of the constitution, the Houthis seized the presidential compound in Sana’a, triggering the resignation of President Hadi and his ministers, who fled first to Aden and then into exile to Saudi Arabia. This was followed by the dissolution of parliament and the formation of a Revolutionary Committee to govern the country on a transitional basis.

The conflict escalated into a full-scale war in March 2015, with the advance of Houthi forces towards Taiz, Aden and other locations in Yemen, against armed opposition from pro-Hadi forces and, eventually, foreign troops. This was accompanied, beginning on 26 March, by airstrikes and shelling from the coalition of countries led by Saudi Arabia, triggering the evacuation of most international organizations, including the United Nations. To the present day, and despite several attempted cease-fires and negotiations, the conflict continues without resolution.

The impact of the conflict has been devastating. Between March 2015 and February 2016, approximately 3,000 civilians were estimated to have been killed, with over 12,000 injured. Approximately 2.3 million people were displaced as of March February 2016, and over 21.1 million people require humanitarian assistance, with 7.6 million facing acute food insecurity, thus placing in on the brink of a man-made famine. The conflict exacerbated an already dire economic and social situation, which in the years following the 2011 crisis had been marked by continued decline of economic growth, rising unemployment and inequality, increasing prices for basic commodities, and the deterioration of state institutional capacities, including provision of core social services, local government and fiscal sustainability.²

1.2 Brief timeline of events

Year/Month	Day	Event
2011		
November		GCC brokered peace agreement, departure of Saleh
2012		
February		Election of President Hadi
2013		

² *Yemen: Preliminary Damage and Needs Assessment*. Report to the Government of Yemen from the World Bank Group, United Nations System, Islamic Development Bank and European Union (May, 2016); *Plan in Response to the Yemen Crisis*. UNDP (August, 2015).

March		Start of National Dialogue
2014		
January	24	End of National Dialogue
August		Fuel subsidies removed; Houthis incite protest in Sana'a
September		Conflict and partial occupation of Sana'a by Houthis; resignation of PM; Signature of the Peace and National Partnership Agreement
November		Establishment of new cabinet led by Khaled Bahah
2015		
January		Houthis reject draft constitution; resignation of President Hadi
February		Houthis seize power and propose transitional 5-member presidential council to place President
March		Houthi advance towards Aden; Escalation of conflict & intervention of Saudi-led coalition; evacuation of international UNDP staff (27 March); all negotiations suspended. UNDP L2 emergency declared
April		Humanitarian Flash Appeal launched for USD 274 million (17 April); new SESG appointed (25 April)
May		Resumption of UN operations in Yemen with limited staff presence; attempt at cease-fire (failed); first round of negotiations (Riyadh) but without Houthis
June		2 nd round of talks begin in Geneva, Switzerland, with all parties. No results reached.
July	1	IASC declares level 3 crisis for Yemen (6 months);
	9	UNDP Crisis Board endorses activation of Level 3 corporate response; 1 st meeting of UNDP CB under L3 response.
	25	UNDP deployment of SURGE planning mission to Amman (until 1 August)
	30	2 nd meeting of the CB
		DNA initiated
August		3 rd CB meeting; approval of UNDP SURGE Plan (implemented until March 2016)
Aug-Sep		Deployment of key SURGE functions/advisors
September	9	4 th CB meeting
		Larnaca Consultations
Oct-Dec		Deployment of remaining SURGE functions/advisors
October	10	5 th CB meeting
	28	Submission of interim SURGE report TO WHO?
December	18	6 th CB meeting. UNDP CB decides on follow-up mission to review SURGE plan implementation
		Yemen Resilience Programme finalized
		UN-sponsored talks in Switzerland following cease-fire (adjourned with limited results)
		New RC/HC/DO appointed (Jamie McGoldrick); RC-HC-DO functions unified
	31	Submission of SURGE support report to the CB
2016		
January	26	IASC Operational Peer Review Report on the response to the Yemen crisis released IASC Level 3 response extended.
March		SURGE Review mission conducted
March		DNA concluded
April	12	7 th CB meeting; endorses SURGE review recommendations on additional support and deployments
		UN-sponsored talks in Kuwait following cease-fire (April to August), end without agreement
		UNDP SURGE Plan deployments completed

1.3 AAR objectives and scope

The objectives of the After Action Review (AAR) are to examine the performance of UNDP with respect to the response to the crisis in Yemen during the period March 2015 – March 2016, and highlight lessons learned that would help strengthen the functioning, performance and efficiency of UNDP response to protracted conflicts. The AAR will also draw recommendations for future crisis response situations. Key elements of the

response reviewed include: UNDPs corporate and country level programmatic and operational response; UN and interagency coordination; and contribution to Disaster Needs Assessment (DNA) and recovery processes.

AAR recommendations are forward-looking, with the aim of identifying best practices and innovations that can be systematized, particularly conflict triggered crisis that tend to adopt a protracted nature, as well as practices that need to be avoided in the future. It will also define areas for further investment and improvement in the response.

Key deliverables of the AAR include:

- A report presenting the key findings, lessons learned and recommendations, focusing on the key issues highlighted above;
- A forward-looking Action Plan for implementing recommendations with a focus on operationalizing the new corporate SOP for immediate crisis response and relevant UNDP crisis response packages, and UNDP's role in transcending the humanitarian-development divide in a post-conflict context;
- A brief summary of key findings and recommendations of the AAR exercise.

1.4 Overview of the report

The present document presents the results of the analysis of the UNDP crisis response undertaken in the context of the AAR, including key findings, lessons learned and recommendations oriented towards improvements in the crisis response SOPs and their application in future crisis situations:

- Section 2 of this document provides a brief overview of the methodology utilized in the AAR to collect and analyze information related to the UNDP crisis response;
- Section 3 presents the core of the AAR findings, and is organized in accordance with the main lines of inquiry as outlined in the ToRs. The presentation of findings consists of an overview of main developments, key analytical findings and lessons learned, and forward looking recommendations.

2. Methodology

Scope. Based on the Terms of Reference, the methodological focus of the AAR was to review the design and implementation of UNDP's response to the Yemen crisis with a focus on identifying those factors (internal UNDP and external contextual factors) that contributed to or limited its overall effectiveness and efficiency. The criteria for assessing the performance of the response and its constituent elements include the corporate SOPs, UNDP's strategic vision for engagement in Yemen, and lessons learned/recommendations from prior crisis responses.

Data collection. Information and data for the AAR was collected from a comprehensive desk review of UNDP documentation, as well as structured interviews and focus group discussions with over 30 key UNDP stakeholders at HQ, regional and country levels (see annex for the list of staff interviewed). Consultative meetings were also held with staff from the Regional Hub in Amman and CO staff (30 April and 1 May, respectively).

Analytical framework. As an after-action review, the analysis is limited to an assessment of the decisions, actions and short-term outputs of the SURGE response as recorded in the documentation and interviews with staff. It is not intended as an evaluation of the overall impact of UNDP's response to the ongoing crisis in Yemen, which would require a longer and empirically-grounded methodological approach. A simple analytical framework has been utilised, with a focus on presenting 'what worked well' and 'what could have worked better'. To verify the validity and accuracy of analytical findings, conclusions and recommendations, a preliminary report will be shared with AAR participants and key stakeholders.

Key criteria for reviewing performance include:

- Timeliness of the response (decisions, deployments, outputs)
- Efficiency (time, process management, coordination, information flow)
- Effectiveness (UNDP positioning, engagement and delivery)

3. Analysis of the UNDP Response

This section examines the overall corporate response to the Yemen crisis from the perspective of its ability to adapt/develop UNDP's strategic vision and approach in the context of new priorities and challenges created by the crisis, align programmatic, operational and financial capabilities and resources accordingly, and position UNDP as a key actor within the international response to the crisis.

In accordance with the AAR Terms of Reference, the main dimensions of the corporate response were reviewed individually, as well as exogenous and contextual factors which directly contributed to the shaping and implementation of the response. These consist of:

- Contextual factors and the operating environment
- Overall corporate response mechanism (Crisis Board, Crisis Management Team)
- Programmatic response
- Operational response
- UN and inter-agency coordination
- Communications and resource mobilization

For each of these areas, a brief overview of main developments (covering the period of review, March 2015-March 2016) is provided, as well as key analytical findings / lessons learned and recommendations geared towards future crisis response exercises.

3.1 Summary overview of main findings and lessons learned

The crisis response in Yemen points to several important overarching findings and lessons learned, which are analyzed in more detail in the subsequent sections :

1. The UNDP crisis response in Yemen demonstrates the strong relevance and importance of its corporate crisis response system in addressing complex and protracted crises, enabling corporate-wide attention and support, and guiding strategic decisions on UNDP's repositioning and reorientation;
2. While there is scope within the current crisis SOPs (2013) to address these types of crises, there is a need to develop specific provisions on corporate engagement and support during pre-crisis phases, as well as over longer time periods in protracted crises situations, with linkages to other corporate change management and support mechanisms to complement temporary surge support.
3. While speed is of the essence in developing corporate SURGE responses, the Yemen case highlights the critical importance of accurately assessing surge needs, ensuring adequate consultation and ownership by frontline units, and ensuring that the modalities of SURGE support are calibrated to maximize the use and effectiveness of resources.
4. The Yemen cause also highlights the importance of ensuring that appropriate senior management capacities are in place to lead the response and take necessary decisions in situations that are both extremely challenging and time-sensitive.
5. In Yemen, the experience of the YRP highlights the importance of striking the right balance between investment in overall strategy formulation and programme portfolio review and development. Early

upfront agreement on UNDP strategic priorities is necessary to inform both portfolio re-alignment and development of new projects, and enable UNDP to engage pro-actively in strategic dialogue with donors and other international partners.

6. Despite being a protracted conflict, the Yemen case also demonstrates the importance of rapidly defining key aspects of the UNDP response (programmatic, advocacy, RM, etc), to enable early engagement and positioning of UNDP with national and international stakeholders. Corporate level crisis response structures (notably the CB) have an important role to ensure compliance of units involved in the response with decisions and in ensuring that critical recovery milestones are achieved in timely manner.
7. Where responding to a crisis entails a significant reorientation of UNDP country programmatic and operational capacities, as was the case in Yemen, an early capacity review should be undertaken to inform both SURGE support and longer-term change management processes.
8. The case of Yemen—where the predominant focus on life-saving humanitarian assistance initially marginalized development and peacebuilding efforts—highlights the importance of UNDP in playing a proactive role in both facilitating dialogue on recovery and resilience priorities, supporting effective coordination among UN and other partners on these issues, and clearly advocating for its role based on identified comparative advantages and programmatic strengths.

3.2 Contextual factors and operating environment

A number of factors relating to the country context, operational and institutional environments influenced the design and implementation of the UNDP crisis response for Yemen. These include:

- **Dynamics of the crisis and conflict in Yemen.** During the period of the crisis response (and beyond) the situation in Yemen was characterized by continued armed conflict, wide-spread insecurity, and the absence of a political solution. The protracted nature of the crisis narrowed the scope for early recovery and resilience programming (with international support focused primarily on provision of humanitarian assistance), the absence of viable national interlocutors, and challenges to assessing and anticipating needs and priorities.
- **Evolution of the international engagement and donor landscape in Yemen during 2015 and 2016,** The evolution of the donor landscape in Yemen during 2015 and 2016 was characterized by a strong focus on humanitarian assistance, and a reluctance of donors to finance early recovery (in the 2016 HRP ER is only 9 % funded). While some attempts were made to engage development-minded donors on recovery issues, notably within the framework of the Damage and Needs Assessment (DNA) led by the World Bank, UN, EU and IsDB, these did not bear fruit until late 2015 / early 2016.
- **Security environment, and implications for staff presence, safety/security, and operations.** The security environment remained extremely challenging throughout the period under review, with continued violence and insecurity resulting in low UN staffing ceilings (with priority accorded to UN agencies implementing ‘life-saving’ activities); limiting UN access and presence outside Sana’a (and hence re-opening sub-office and project sites); and significantly increasing security costs for staff relocation/evacuation and project implementation.
- **Division within the UN coordination architecture in Yemen.** Until December 2015 the RC/DO and HC functions were divided, and also worked separately from the UN Special Envoy for Yemen. This contributed to coordination challenges within the UN system, constrained a more holistic approach to UN political, humanitarian and development efforts, and created tensions with respect to security management. This was changed at the end of 2015 with the unification of the functions and appointment of the new RC/HC.

- **Corporate UNDP organizational restructuring.** The response to the crisis in Yemen took place in the context of a reorganization and change management process within UNDP, with new structures being established at HQ and regional levels. This engendered a certain lack of clarity on the instruments to be utilised in the context of a crisis response, as well as turn-over of staff. and lack of clarity on many of the instruments which the Organization used to rely on for crisis response – e.g. Thematic Windows, etc.

3.3 Overall corporate response

For the purposes of this review, the overall corporate response is broken down into three elements, which are reviewed separately in this section:

- **Corporate response mechanism** (Crisis Board and Crisis Management Team). Immediate crisis management phase (preceding and following declaration of L3 emergency), including analysis of the information flows, L3 activation criteria, coordination and discussions/decisions;
- **SURGE response**, including development of the SURGE plan, deployment of advisors (including timelines, profiles, and functional placement), outputs, integration with UNDP country programme and operations, draw-down, post-SURGE follow-up support and sustainability plan;
- **UNDP CO strategic positioning, capacities** (programmatic, operational, managerial and financial) prior to and following onset of crisis in March 2015, and measures in place to anticipate/manage contingencies (business continuity plan, risk management framework etc.).

3.3.1 Corporate Crisis Response Mechanism (Crisis Board, CSMT)

Main Developments

- **UNDP declared a Level 2 emergency in March 2015, following the escalation of violence and coalition-led bombardments in Sana’a.** The Crisis Board and CMT were established and met to discuss developments and coordinate provision of support to the CO. During this time, the focus of efforts were on security and safety of staff, including evacuation of international staff to Amman, relocation of national staff, and maintaining business continuity for critical UNDP functions and services.
- **On 8 July the IASC declared a Level 3 emergency with Yemen.** The declaration of an L3 entails a “system-wide mobilization of capacity (**leadership, staffing and funding**) to enable accelerated and scaled-up delivery of assistance and protection to people in need”, and is intended to result in enhanced leadership and coordination capacities and the mobilization of IASC member agencies to respond to urgent needs. As noted in the IASC Operational Peer Review of January 2016, the implementation of L3 was constrained by risk-averse security management practices, which imposed a strict ceiling for UN staff and the fragmentation of coordination functions between the RC/DO and HC, which was compounded by additional coordination functions (Regional HC and Special Advisor to the ERC). Another challenge that emerged was the disconnect between the programme criticality framework and the determination of staff ceilings and slots within the security management system, which created an important challenge in ensuring adequate staffing for critical programmes.
- **Between March and July, when the L3 response was activated, RBAS took the lead as per the SOPs in coordinating ad-hoc SURGE support to the CO.** This included the deployment of several individual SURGE missions, including Senior Early Recovery expert (Charles Von Huff) in June to advise the CO on UNDP positioning in the overall humanitarian response and a Results and Resources Management Specialist (Abusabeeb Elsadiq) to support the CO on resource planning, management and financial sustainability. Additional SURGE advisors deployed during this period included an operations manager and information management officer (for the ER cluster). The UNDP Regional Hub based in Amman supported CO staff based there in undertaking a conflict analysis and developing several strategic

programming frameworks, including on recovery and resilience which eventually was utilized as the basis for the Yemen Resilience Programme.

- **A TRAC 3 Cat. 2 allocation of US\$140,000 was authorized** in June 2015 and utilized to fund an early recover needs assessment and a solid waste management assessment, both of which were used to inform the ER cluster strategy and waste management programming.
- **UNDP activated the L3 response and initiated the SURGE planning process following the declaration of level 3 emergency by the IASC.** The UNDP L3 corporate response was activated rapidly following the IASC level 3 declaration on 1 July, at the meeting of the CB held on 9 July. This was followed shortly by the deployment of a SURGE planning mission (25 July – 1 August) which worked with the CO in developing an integrated response plan, including guidance on CO positioning, review of the CO structure and programme, and providing advisory support on the prioritization and realignment of CO programme portfolios. The SURGE Plan, including a budget of US\$ 1,244,530, developed through this mission was approved by the Crisis Board at its meeting on 10 August 2015.
- **SURGE deployment commenced shortly thereafter, with most advisors being deployed between August-December 2015.** During this period, the CB met periodically to review progress on SURGE and to endorse key outputs and recommendations (including extensions of advisors in December 2015 and April 2016). A total of 12 SURGE Advisors were deployed during this period, working primarily from Amman (see 3.2.2 below). Four advisors were subsequently extended beyond the initial 3 month period until March 2016.
- **Six months following the L3 activation, the CB requested a follow-on mission to review the implementation of the SURGE plan.** This mission was fielded jointly by the CRU and RBAS-RH between 28 February- 2 March 2016, and recommended additional SURGE support measures, including extension of some SURGE advisors. These recommendations were approved by the CB at its meeting on 12 April 2016.

Findings

- **The majority of individuals consulted for the AAR expressed satisfaction with the functioning of the Crisis Board and Crisis Management Team following the L3 activation in July 2015.** The CB was generally considered an adequately responsive and useful mechanism for coordinating the response and assistance to the CO, which most feel was provided in timely manner following the activation of the L3 phase. At the same time, interviews with staff revealed a number of challenges and issues, which while not compromising the overall response, could have improved its overall effectiveness and efficiency.
- **Corporate engagement and support to the CO could have been contemplated earlier than the March crisis and L2 activation.** The deterioration of the situation in Yemen was evident as early as September 2014. Discussions within the CO on indicators of increasing conflict risks were held at the programme, operations and senior management levels, including possible programme reorientation in January 2015, but no concrete decisions emerged from these processes. Similarly, in January 2015, UNDP HQ entities held several discussions with the CO on possible options for adapting its programme given the trajectory of the crisis, but with no discernible management actions or decisions.³ While no UN system contingency planning exercise was organized at country level, discussions in several inter-agency fora at HQ level could have provided opportunities for initiating reflection on possible CO strengthening and re-alignment. Finally, several aspects of the CO's operations capacity in need of strengthening had been previously identified (including through previous audits), and could have been addressed in anticipation of a reorientation of CO focus. This points to the need to consider a crisis focus in the regular UNDP change management process, including linkage to the crisis response SOPs and earlier involvement of CRU.

³ UNDP Management was also advised by the Office of the Special Envoy to Yemen not to divert from the established approach to supporting the post-2011 transition process for political messaging purposes.

- **Given the length of time between the outbreak of the crisis in March and the L3 activation in July, consideration should have been given to deeper corporate engagement and earlier SURGE planning.** In the view of a number of staff consulted during the AAR, the CO could have benefited from stronger corporate and SURGE support during the period until July, and a longer period of preparation of the L3 SURGE plan itself. Some felt the gap of nearly four months was too long, given the nature of the crisis, and the urgency and scale of support required by the CO. While a number of individual SURGE missions were fielded during this time, it is not clear whether they were sufficient to address the scale of these needs. Earlier planning of SURGE support could have prevented the eventual ‘rush to deploy’ in late July, and averted some of the misperceptions, tensions and confusion that arose around the roles, profiles and responsibilities of some of the SURGE advisors.

While CO and CB efforts were primarily (and correctly) focused on staff safety and security and business continuity, more attention and support could have been given to laying the groundwork for the subsequent SURGE deployment, in line with the provisions of phases 0 and 1 of the corporate crisis response SOPs. That said, providing immediate and urgent support to the CO on evacuations and business continuity while at the same time beginning to work on a longer-term crisis response can be challenging when the CO is in the middle of a serious crisis and is planning on a day to day basis with limited bandwidth for longer-term planning. One approach that could be contemplated is establishing dedicated crisis response work-streams, potentially managed by separate task forces reporting to the CB or CMST.

- **The restructuring of UNDP at corporate level in 2014 is also considered to have impacted the overall efficiency of the corporate crisis response.** This, in the views of some, affected the quality and timeliness of the response, particularly during the L2 phase, during which roles and responsibilities had not yet settled. During the height of the crisis in March, there was a perception that the ‘CO was on its own’ with insufficient (and at times reactive) corporate engagement and guidance on key immediate crisis management issues (notably evacuation and financing).

Lack of clarity also existed around the RH, which in early 2015 was still in the process of being established. This included the role of BPPS staff posted in Amman versus their counterparts at HQ level in other departments, and led to some tensions between the Regional Hub and the SURGE mission once it deployed as of August 2015. This could have been avoided by upfront clarification of roles early during the L3 response, earlier participation of RH in the CB/CMST (which only occurred after deployment of SURGE team commenced in August), and inclusion of a RH focal point to coordinate the RH’s engagement in the crisis response, and with the SURGE team in particular. As a general point, regular communications between the RH--given their role as first responders, but also proximity, knowledge and close relationships with COs--and the corporate crisis response structure should be established as early in the crisis as possible.

- **The development of the SURGE plan encountered some challenges, highlighting the importance of adequate coordination and consultations with all stakeholders.** In the views of a number of staff, the SURGE planning team was fielded too suddenly, catching some colleagues at HQ, the RH and in the CO by surprise, and was not aligned with visits of the CO Senior Management to Amman (both were absent during this period). Some staff felt the plan should have been consulted more widely with CO staff and the Regional Hub. This appeared to have impacted the sense of CO ownership over the plan and created a sense of disconnect with the Regional Hub, leading to misperceptions and communication gaps not conducive to collaboration and effective coordination down the road. Sufficient time should be allowed for the development of the SURGE plan, to ensure adequate consultation around identification of SURGE needs and corresponding support functions and modalities.

A further issue was the reversal of decisions on staffing contained in the SURGE plan by CO Senior Management following its approval by the CB in August, including on the dual role of the SURGE Team Leader as DCD/P and the terms of reference of some advisors. The ensuing frustration and lack of clarity

on the roles and responsibilities of some SURGE advisors could have been avoided by ensuring a full discussion and final decision on the Plan at the level of the CB.

- **Consideration of alternative modalities of SURGE support and more flexible use of resources could have been beneficial.** It is not clear to a number of staff why SURGE support was limited to the deployment of international advisors (UNDP staff and consultants). In hindsight, given the lack of access to Yemen, the constrained resource mobilization environment, and the limited capacity of the CO to absorb the full SURGE team, additional or alternative modalities could have been explored. This could have included direct provision of some of the funds ear-marked for Yemen SURGE support (which were eventually used for deployment of SURGE advisors) to the CO for crisis programming (urgent interventions and pilots) and mobilizing local expertise, including direct contracting of national experts, national UNVs, NGOs, and other service providers (through existing LTAs) in Yemen.
- **At the same time, it is evident that the level of engagement and support provided through the crisis response (the SURGE deployment) probably should have been maintained in some form beyond March 2016.** Given that SURGE response is normally a three-month investment (which was extended to more than 6 for some advisors in the case of Yemen), this points to the need for a different approach in the context of complex and protracted crises such as Yemen, and a greater corporate agility in being able to respond and resource support before, during and after a crisis. In the case of Yemen, the need for a large ‘front-loaded’ SURGE deployment (which was largely seen as necessary by most staff consulted) should have been balanced with considerations of how to maintain a sufficient level of support over the longer term in order to address the issues that arose (notably the delays in moving from programme development to implementation, mobilizing resources, and reconfiguring and restaffing the CO). At the same time, there is need to maintain clear limits on the scope of SURGE support – it should not become an open-ended substitute for other corporate change management and support processes.
- **Stronger CB support and guidance on key elements of the response to the Yemen crisis could have been beneficial.** The CO operated in a very challenging operational environment for most of 2015, and despite SURGE support, experienced some difficulties in preparing key elements of the response on time and inserting UNDP forcefully enough in processes of dialogue with other international partners and donors. With hindsight, greater CB/CMST engagement and support to the CO, by leveraging corporate positioning, established partnerships, and access to global-level coordination could have helped it more quickly and easily reposition its programme portfolio, develop partnerships and mobilize resources.
- **The Crisis Board should have been more assertive and strict in ensuring compliance with its decisions and insisting on deadlines for key elements of the UNDP response (including SURGE deliverables).** A number of key programme, staffing and resource mobilization decisions or deliverables were delayed or questioned, which could have been avoided with more upfront clarity in what were executive decisions (as prerogatives of the CB under L3) and what were negotiated decisions requiring full buy-in from different parts of UNDP. This points to the need for clearer accountability on core crisis response priorities between HQ and CO, and delegation of authority for responsibilities to be exercised.

Recommendations

1. In situations of complex and protracted crises under level 2 and 3 responses, UNDP’s crisis response mechanisms needs to be more adept at understanding the political context and flexible in adapting to fluid and unpredictable environments/situations, latitude for which is provided in both the current (2013) and draft crisis response SOPs (dated 2016).
2. UNDP’s Crisis Response SOPs should provide clearer guidance on addressing ‘pre-crisis’ but clearly deteriorating situations (‘slow-onset’ crises), with options including earlier activation of the crisis response (under either L1 or L2 phases) or the formal inclusion of a pre-crisis phase. Pre-crisis response and support could include early warning analysis and monitoring, contingency and preparedness planning

and positioning, ‘crisis’ focused change management support and programmatic/thematic advisory support, as well as engagement in inter-agency level contingency and crisis mechanisms.

3. On early warning, consideration should be given to some form of structured process for corporate monitoring of potential crisis situations (including possibly through the Executive Team or through an inter-agency process such as the SG’s Regular Monthly Review (RMR) meetings). Such processes could provide a mechanism for monitoring and triggering UNDP preventive actions at country level, which in turn could be financed through Trac 3.2 or other UNDP resources.
4. Criteria and timelines for triggering the L3 phase and SURGE support should be re-examined to accurately assess emergency response priorities and develop the corresponding SURGE plan. Where necessary, this could entail delinking UNDP L3 activation from the IASC L3 (which the SOPs already provide for), and/or contemplating a phased approach to SURGE planning beginning as early as possible (including pre-planning prior to formal L3 activation). Linkages to UN-wide monitoring mechanisms (including the Regular Monthly Review process) could also be useful in informing UNDP crisis response planning triggers.
5. In contexts of protracted crises, and/or situations where CO needs require a longer-term investment in terms of support, UNDP should consider options for either a) extending or phasing SURGE support to ensure sufficient ‘spread’ of expertise and resources required to achieve critical programme, operations and RM milestones; or b) linking provision of short-term SURGE support to a longer-term corporate process of change management. In the case of the former, consideration of an ‘extended’ or ‘protracted L3’ phase should be considered, with separate timelines and modalities for provision of support (which could be staggered or phased), including through other corporate mechanisms, over the duration of a protracted crisis.
6. In contexts of complex and major crises, a strategic corporate focus on programmatic, RM, operations and advocacy issues is essential, both to leverage the full breadth of corporate resources, positioning and relationships, and to ensure continuity of effort when country-level engagement alone on these issues is insufficient.
7. The roles and responsibilities of UNDP Regional Hubs and BPPS advisors co-located therein should be codified and institutionalized as part of the crisis response SOPs in the context of both L2 and L3 responses, and across the various phases of the SURGE response. RH expertise and experience should be integrated as much as possible in SURGE support, and appropriate coordination mechanisms established to maximize synergies.
8. When developing the SURGE assistance package, the full range of modalities as outlined in the corporate SOPs (2013 and draft 2016 versions) should be considered and discussed at the level of the CB and CMT, to ensure that the support provided is optimized to the needs and load-bearing capacity of the CO.
9. The development and implementation of the crisis response is by definition a corporate management tool, but should be founded on the principles of partnership and collaboration between the various entities involved, and in particular with COs. In this context, executive decision making should be balanced with adequate consultation and coordination to ensure consensus on strategy and tools, and appropriate sensitivity and adaptation to country realities.⁴
10. In crisis situations where timely decisions, actions and results are of critical importance, the CB needs to exercise appropriate oversight over accountability and responsibility, and ensure compliance with decisions and timelines.

3.3.2 SURGE Deployment

Main Developments

⁴ This is now reflected in the current draft of the UNDP Crisis Response SOPs (dated 2016), which place corporate support to the CO’s at the “front and center” of the response.

- The SURGE plan set out a comprehensive package of support to the CO for reorienting and strengthening its strategic, programmatic and operational capacities and positioning in Yemen.** Based on an assessment of UNDP Yemen's programme and operational capacities, strategic considerations for its engagement in the crisis context, a new programme strategy focused on local governance, livelihoods and social services, and essential capacities required to reposition UNDP accordingly, the SURGE plan proposed a number of SURGE functions to be deployed over a period of 3-6 months.
- Implementation of the SURGE plan was undertaken through the provision of 11 functions, against which SURGE advisors were deployed.** Eight of these functions were supported by advisors fielded for a period of three months, while four were supported by advisors fielded for a period of 6 months. An Early Recovery Advisor was also included in the SURGE staffing plan, but not deployed. Non-staffing component of the SURGE plan included financing for security equipment and provisions. The total financial requirement of the SURGE deployment amounted to US\$ 1,244,530, and included US\$124,000 for security requirements. The SURGE functions deployed were as follows:
 - Resource mobilization Adviser (P5) (*)
 - Communication Specialist (P3)
 - Risk Management Advisor (Amman) (P4)
 - ER Cluster Coordinator (P3) (*)
 - Operations Specialist (P4) (*)
 - Management Support (Financial) Advisor (P3)
 - Monitoring and Evaluation Specialist (Sana'a) (P3)
 - DCD/P - Resilience Programme Management (P5) (*)
 - Senior Advisor / UN Coordinator (DNA)
 - Community livelihoods/recovery Spec. (P3/P4)
 - Mine Action Specialist (P4)
- SURGE advisors were responsible for or contributed to a number of important deliverables as part of the overall corporate crisis response.** These included:
 - **Development of the YRP strategy and programme formulation**, including results framework, coordination mechanisms and management structure;
 - **Operations and financial management support**, including management of daily operations activities and functions, preparation of SOPs and guidance on issues related to procurement, HR, finance, remote management and use of NGO implementation modality; and provision of training for CO staff.
 - **Resource mobilization**, including development of an overall resource mobilization strategy, preparation of concept /briefing notes for donor meetings; development of a donor tracking system; and preparation of key messages and support for meeting organization;
 - **Advocacy and communication**, including an overall communications strategy, guidelines for producing communications material, protocols for press release; and development of communication training modules, among other products;
 - **Early recovery coordination**, through fielding of an ER Cluster Coordinator who was responsible for chairing the ER cluster and leading on planning for humanitarian appeals;
 - **DNA coordination**, through the deployment of a strategic and planning advisor who coordinated UN system engagement in the DNA process.
- Continuity and sustainability of SURGE assistance.** As indicated in the SURGE team and review reports (December 2015 and February 2016, respectively), maintaining continuity (in the form of a phase out plan) was not an option given that the re-profiling of the CO staffing structure was not yet complete at

the end of the SURGE period. Several SURGE assignments were extended to help bridge this gap in the first quarter of 2016.

Findings

- **Overall, the focus, scale, timing and outputs of the SURGE deployment were considered timely and relevant given the nature of the crisis and the needs of the CO,** and contributed significantly to both reorienting and positioning the CO (through the YRP, which now forms the backbone of UNDP's country programme) and new donor partnerships and programme funding. At the same time, the design and implementation of the SURGE plan faced a number of constraints and challenges which impacted both its efficiency and overall effectiveness.
- **The inability of most SURGE advisors, including the Team Leader, to travel to Sana'a constituted an important constraint and challenge to the effectiveness of SURGE support.** The SURGE Team Leader did his best (which was much appreciated by CO management and staff) to ensure close working relations between the CO and the SURGE team, but the necessity of operating from Amman significantly reduced possibilities for interaction with CO staff and placed serious constraints on the ability of the SURGE team to contextualize or truth-check their analyses and recommendations. Given the significant impact of this constraint, alternative avenues could also have been explored, including negotiating unused slots with other agencies, deploying advisors over a longer cycle in staggered/phased fashion, and also making better use of in-country expertise (national experts, NGOs, etc.). CO management should also have established an appropriate framework ensuring cross-team collaboration and shared accountability for common response deliverables. At a minimum, the SURGE Team Leader should have been accorded access to Sana'a as a priority, which could have done much to improve coordination and the effectiveness of the SURGE team.⁵
- **The identification of SURGE functions and corresponding staff could have been better assessed and managed.** A number of UNDP interlocutors felt that the identification of SURGE functions did not sufficiently take into account gaps in CO expertise and critically needed functions. As a result of inadequate coordination with the RH and CO, there was some degree of duplication of functions (for instance with respect to livelihoods and governance, where both the CO and RH had staff with requisite thematic expertise), as well as considerable time lost in the selection, vetting and release of staff (which while not problematic for Yemen might not have been conducive to an effective response in a context where deployment speed was critical). More careful planning should have gone into the definition of SURGE functions and the selection of advisors, including through an examination of available expertise at the level of the RH and CO. In the views of some, this could have resulted in a more balanced SURGE deployment, including more emphasis on operations, where the CO lacked critical capacities (including for instance on HR, finance, project closure and DTF establishment).
- **The effectiveness of the SURGE deployment was mitigated in some cases by lack of clarity on terms of reference and post-deployment decisions reversing agreeing functions and responsibilities of SURGE advisors.** Following the approval of the SURGE plan and initiation of deployments, issues around SURGE functions and deployments continued, including unclear terms of references, or changes in SURGE functions after they had been agreed by the CB. The decision to double-hat the SURGE team leader as Deputy Country Director for Programmes was also questioned and re-opened by the CO senior management, which was not conducive to optimal interaction and the integration of the SURGE with the CO. This highlights the need for there to have been earlier and better consultation and agreement between HQ, RH and CO on needed functions, ToRs and profiles prior to and following finalization of the SURGE Plan.

⁵ The SURGE Team Leader was only able to visit Sana'a in February 2016, at the end of the SURGE deployment period, which is clearly not conducive to maximizing the effectiveness of SURGE support.

- **More attention should have been given to the ability of the CO to absorb a large SURGE team (6-12 people), given its situation.** At the time of the SURGE deployment beginning in August 2015, the CO was operating with a skeleton staff given the evacuations and relocations, while at the same time working around the clock to maintain UNDP services in an extremely challenging operational and business environment. This by definition imposed limits on the CO's ability to fully engage with, support and coordinate with the SURGE team. While individual SURGE advisors were nonetheless able to develop close collaborative relationships with Sana'a based staff despite the physical distance, limits to the CO's absorptive capacity should have been taken into account when planning SURGE deployments.
- **National staff based in Sana'a felt they were not adequately consulted in the development of the SURGE plan, or kept abreast of SURGE team activities.** While some SURGE advisors developed close working relationships with Sana'a based staff despite working remotely, the latter felt that for the most part they did not know who was who or what they were working on. This resulted in important disconnects, notably between the SURGE programme advisors and CO programme staff, and with operations. National staff should have been engaged from the outset to ensure clarity and inputs on the SURGE workplan, and to develop working relationships with individual advisors.
- **Given the protracted nature of the Yemen crisis, a longer or more continuous form of SURGE support might have been warranted.** While the 'front-loading' of SURGE support during the second half of 2015 was clearly required, the CO did require additional engagement and support beyond this period, particularly as the focus began to shift from planning to implementation and operations in the first half of 2016. In protracted crisis contexts needs and challenges will continue to evolve. While the CO would have benefited from a more staggered approach on some aspects of the response (notably programmatic, to ensure adequate support for both programme design and implementation), the focus on up-front capacities on operations and resource mobilization was deemed appropriate given the urgency of these issues, and did enable the organization to concentrate a broad range of skills and expertise on a constellation of complex and urgent issues at the right time.
- **The overall sustainability of SURGE support was mixed.** While the SURGE team did provide important inputs and advice which helped the CO address a number of critical programmatic, operations, communications and RM issues, the extent to which these inputs and advice continued to be used and SURGE functions maintained by the CO varied. In part this was due to insufficient capacity in the CO (including the staffing gap that still existed following the end of the SURGE deployment); delays in mobilizing new financial resources through the YRP, and a lack of sufficient ownership by CO staff in some of the products developed by the SURGE (partly attributed to remote management issues). In hindsight, consideration should have been given to a clear and agreed 'handover and transition agreement' with the CO, some mechanism of flagging key SURGE recommendations for subsequent monitoring and review by the CB, and corporate engagement in ensuring that the gap between SURGE and CO staffing was minimized to allow for continuity (perhaps integrated as part of a CO capacity assessment).

Recommendations

1. In situations where the remote management and provision of SURGE support is necessary, adequate measures are required to ensure adequate interaction, coordination and integration between SURGE and CO teams. This includes prioritizing sufficient access to the country for SURGE advisors (and notably the Team Leader), negotiating additional staffing slots, oversight of cross-team collaboration by CO Senior Management, and ensuring that the CRT meets regularly using all available means.
2. Definition of SURGE functions, corresponding terms of reference, and identification/selection of advisors should be carefully planned and agreed between the CRU, Regional Bureaus, Central Bureaus, Regional Hub and the CO to ensure that deployments conform to needs, avoid duplication on staffing, and provide relevant expertise.
3. SURGE deployment timelines should take into account capacity of the CO to absorb and support staff and consultants, as well as the expected timelines for delivery of key crisis response outputs, with an emphasis

on balancing the need for up-front capacity with making most effective use of SURGE resources in the overall process of CO reorientation and strengthening.

4. In order to facilitate the sustainability of SURGE functions following the end of SURGE support, SURGE teams should include handover and transition of functions as part of their responsibilities, and COs should be responsible for committing to measures and timelines for ensuring sustainability. These should be discussed and agreed by the CB prior to the conclusion of the SURGE mission, and monitored to ensure compliance, with additional support being provided as necessary (including through a linked change management and other corporate processes).

3.3.3 UNDP Country Office

Main Developments

- At the time of the March 2015 crisis, the UNDP CO was configured for support to the post-2011 transition process, with a USD 30 million portfolio primarily focused on core governance functions, transitional justice, and elections. In the period preceding the crisis, the CO was also expanding programming at sub-national level on livelihoods and local governance (3x6), including cash for work linked to enterprise development.
- As mentioned, discussions were held on the deteriorating political and security situation in Yemen as early as September 2014, but this did not result in any contingency planning or requests for support to strengthen CO capacities from risk prevention and preparedness perspectives. According to staff interviewed, the CO's business continuity plan was not well developed prior to the crisis, and should have been prioritized in the immediate pre-crisis period and could have helped address some of the operational issues that constrained the response to the crisis down the line.
- During and immediately following the March crisis, the CO was entirely focused on staff security and safety, including the evacuation and relocation of staff, and ensuring business continuity around critical functions and services (notably finances);
- The crisis had a significant impact on UNDP's capacity. It was essentially operating with a core skeleton staff, confronted with significant operating challenges (office space, electricity, communications and cash payments).
- In addition, and as assessed by the SURGE planning mission in July-August 2015, the CO had several important capacity gaps:
 - Programming: lack of staff on livelihoods and CPR (due to turn-over)
 - Programme integration: absence of programme coordination function
 - Operations management: absence of capacity and experience in complex procurement, contract management and asset management
 - Insufficient MSU capacity to manage scaling up in operations and oversight requirements
- CO financial sustainability took a big hit in 2015 due to withdrawal of donor funding and high costs associated with staff relocation (outside and inside country) and security. By 2016 situation improved due to EU, Japan funding for projects, WB 300 million USD, as well as funding for stabilization in the south (USAID funding).
- Immediately following the crisis, UNDP's high priority was to reposition itself quickly in a dramatically changed environment, which entailed significant reorientation of programmatic and operations work and capacities. This was complicated by the development of a humanitarian response in which UNDP and

recovery/resilience programming was not deemed critical from a life-saving perspective. This limited prospects for early positioning and imposed serious constraints on presence of international staff due to limited slots accorded to UNDP (which during the period under review was limited to 3-4 slots for UNDP international staff, including security, early recovery coordination (cluster system) and DTF management.⁶

Findings

- **The CO should have been supported in developing crisis preparedness and contingency plans before the March 2015 crisis, when indicators of a worsening security and political climate became clear.** This could have included staff training on crisis response and preparedness planning, as well as initial assessments of programmatic and operations capacity strengthening as part of contingency planning. While the CO received SURGE support on an ad hoc basis from March until the main SURGE deployment in August, there is a question as to whether these missions were sufficient from the perspective of broader organizational strengthening and preparedness, which could have enabled them to be better placed when the crisis did unfold in March.
- **Security management was one area where action was taken on preparedness prior to the March 2015 crisis,** focusing on measures to absorb potential shocks and mitigate eventual risks. These included training for CO staff, stockpiling of food and fuel, provision of equipment and procurement of armored vehicles. During the crisis, additional measures included procurement of solar panels and national staff were also provided with generators at home to facilitate establishment of work ‘hubs’ outside the office. At the same time, the weak operational capacity of the CO was considered to have constituted a risk from a security management perspective, underscoring the importance of strengthening these capacities as a matter of priority in crisis situations.
- **UNDP’s crisis response SOPs contain a provision to assess required leadership and management capacities in situations of crisis, and take appropriate decisions on strategic staffing.** It is unclear to what extent this provision was considered or applied in the context of Yemen. Opinions from staff consulted during this review indicate that such an assessment could have been beneficial and helped prevent some of the management challenges encountered (and which are referenced throughout this document). This issue should have been monitored closely at corporate level, with decisions taken on management early in the response.
- **The case of Yemen also highlights the importance of additional corporate financing to support the financial sustainability of COs when confronted with major and unexpected shocks.** A number of staff interviewed stated that the then-prevailing corporate view and expectation was that COs should manage crisis-related costs on their own. In contexts where CO’s financial sustainability is affected by increased and unforeseen costs—which in the case of Yemen was exacerbated by the suspension of significant amounts of programme funding—additional corporate financial resources could have constituted a critical element in facilitating the timely repositioning and re-orientation of programmes and operations.

Recommendations

1. In complex crises and emergencies, where the role of CO senior management is deemed critical, the review and assessment of CO management capacities, as foreseen in the Crisis Response SOPs, should be mandatory, in order to ensure an appropriate composition of skills and experience.

⁶ The initial staff ceiling for the UN as a whole following the March 2015 crisis allowed 17 international UN staff into Yemen. This was increased incrementally to more than 105 slots (37 reserved for UNDSS security staff) as of 14 October 2015, but fluctuated.

2. In contexts of slow onset and complex emergencies, crisis preparedness and contingency planning (covering both programme and operations) should be prioritized and undertaken either as an internal UNDP exercise or as part of a broader UN system efforts. Such planning should be mandatory for COs, and be utilized to also inform discussions at corporate level on possible crisis response approaches and modalities.
3. In contexts where CO's are confronted with unexpected and significant financial expenditures—either as a result of increased costs due to evacuation and security, or suspension of funds needed for core expenditures—some form of emergency corporate financing should be made available, perhaps on a reimbursable basis, to allow the CO to ensure its financial sustainability and provide 'space' for expenditure planning related to CO programmatic and operations reprofiling/reorientation.

3.4 Programmatic response

This section examines the programmatic component of the response in terms of its ability to define programmatic priorities and approaches based on an understanding of UNDP's overall strategic vision for crisis response, identified national priorities for crisis management and recovery, UNDP's comparative advantage and contribution in relation to other actors, resource mobilization potential and ability to leverage in-country and regional/HQ programmatic, operational and financial resources. Key issues examined during the review included:

- Decision-making around the scope/options for the programmatic response, e.g.: portfolio-wide, programme/project revision, new programmatic interventions.
- Relevance and 'fit' of programmatic response with broader UNDP strategic vision and national/international priorities;
- Integration of programmatic response within broader UNDP country programme framework;
- 'Grounding' of programmatic response through consultations with national, international and other stakeholders.
- Degree of scalability, adaptability and identified resource mobilization potential.

Main Developments

- **The programmatic component of the crisis response—and a key focus of the support provided through the SURGE team—was the development of a programme strategy centered around the principles of increased delivery/impact, conflict sensitivity, and a flexible and risk-oriented approach.** This was articulated in the form of the Yemen Resilience Programme, finalized in December 2015, which was meant to serve as an overarching strategic framework for the country programme (akin to a CPD). The programme strategy was intended to fit within the overall humanitarian approach in Yemen, and, in particular, on how to address needs in protracted conflict and constrained operating environment; re-orient and create a coherent UNDP programmatic approach, building on existing UNDP competencies and track record in-country (particularly in the areas of youth employment and local governance); and provide a basis for engaging donors on resource mobilization.
- **Formulation of the YRP.** The YRP was formulated on the basis of initial concepts developed prior to the SURGE deployment, between March-May, during a period of intense collaboration between CO relocated to Amman and Regional Hub staff. These were used by the SURGE team as the basis for the full YRP document. While intended to provide a vision and framework for CO programme and operations in the short term, the YRP was only finalized and approved in December 2015. Prior to its finalization, a series of short notes and briefs on the draft YRP were prepared and utilized for outreach to donors on resource mobilization.

- **The YRP was formulated alongside a process of programme portfolio review**, conducted by the CO with support of RBAS, which was driven by need to renegotiate donor funding and determine fit and relevance with the changed environment. A number of projects – mostly in the area of support to the transitional governance were closed as a result (either because irrelevant or because donors withdrew funding, e.g. PBF). Livelihood projects were reoriented with new target groups or locations. HR rights was reoriented away from capacity building to protection. Also, the CO renegotiated projects in final stages of approval (2 projects with EU, UN joint programme on resilience, and social inclusion).
- **The SURGE team also supported the CO in developing the M&E framework for the YRP** and providing advice on the internal risk management structure and internal control framework.
- **There was limited success in reorienting existing programme financing to address crisis priorities during 2015**, and resource mobilization remained extremely challenging given the ongoing crisis and limited donor interest in recovery and development funding – in particular in the months following the start of the armed escalation.
- **In 2016, following its approval, the YRP was formally linked to CPD and constitutes the backbone of the project tree for the CO.** It also is understood to have contributed to establishing a foundation for subsequent programme development and resource mobilization efforts, including with the World Bank, USAID and the EU.

Findings

- **Overall, the programmatic dimension of UNDP's crisis response, which focused on the concurrent development of the YRP and the review of the programme portfolio, enabled UNDP to reorient its focus to address critical livelihood and resilience strengthening priorities.** While progress on both fronts was constrained by a number of challenges which are outlined below, most interlocutors interviewed for this review expressed the view that both the YRP and portfolio review were critical in repositioning UNDP over the longer term, leveraging the organization's in-country comparative advantages and expertise, and laying the foundation for the significant growth in the programme portfolio in 2016.
- **Given the need to quickly position UNDP, mobilise resources and resume delivery, the finalization and approval of the YRP took far too long.** Numerous delays (attributed in part to differing views between the RH, RBAS, CRU and the CO) resulted in the YRP only being finalized in December 2015 – 9 months after the crisis. In the views of staff consulted, this undermined both UNDP's attempt to build relations with donors and quickly mobilise needed funding, and arguably UNDP's attempt to position itself in the broader humanitarian response. In retrospect, UNDP could have opted for a more rapid or streamlined review and approval process, or a 'phased' adoption of the YRP strategy (beginning with a decision on the overall objectives, approach and priorities early on in the crisis, followed by subsequent decisions on the complete framework once complete). This is an example of one the decisions where an 'executive decision' of the CB early on to fast-track this process would have been beneficial.
- **At the same time, a more balanced approach was needed between developing a holistic and overarching programme framework and addressing the need for visible, tangible actions on the ground.** While the need and importance of the YRP is indisputable given its importance in positioning UNDP and the resilience/recovery agenda in Yemen, it came at the expense of a faster resumption of programme delivery on the ground. In the views of staff consulted, the development of an overarching framework should have been accompanied by greater emphasis on development of shorter-term interventions that could have been used to test new approaches and respond to opportunities for engagement, both of which could have helped raise UNDP visibility and engage with donors. Such interventions could have been aligned with the broader humanitarian response, while at the same time building entry points for longer-term development focused interventions. CO colleagues consulted felt that too much effort was dedicated by the SURGE team to development of the YRP framework, and

insufficient emphasis placed on supporting project development (which the SURGE team did support, but only following the finalization of the YRP in December 2015).

Furthermore, given the volatility and unpredictability of the situation, some question whether a highly structured programme framework – rather than a lighter strategy (limited to 1-2 objectives) that could be adjusted as the context (and needs/priorities) evolved, would have been more appropriate.

In the views of a number of UNDP staff consulted, the ideal sequencing in 2015 would have consisted on development of overall vision/strategy for the CO in the 1-2 months after the crisis (which some CO staff feel was achieved), followed by a concerted focus in the remainder of the year on utilizing SURGE support to develop short-term interventions (designing project documents and putting in place arrangements for implementation), while restructuring and re-aligning others.

- **The YRP also appears to have been affected by a lack of clarity within UNDP on its ultimate purpose.** Some entities within UNDP considered it to be a broad strategic framework, essentially a Country Programme Document, against which individual programmes and projects would be aligned and/or developed. Others viewed it as a stand-alone programme or as a resource mobilization tool to present to donors. This ambiguity should have been resolved through decision at senior management level (CB and CO) at an early stage to provide clarity to all teams working on programmatic response.
- **Lack of clarity on how the development of the YRP was related to and influenced the review of the UNDP programme portfolio, which was being undertaken concurrently with the support of RBAS.** From interviews with staff involved in both processes, it does not appear that both processes were sufficiently linked and aligned. This is due in part to the geographical distance between the SURGE advisors and the CO programme staff in Sana'a, and also highlights the importance of pro-active engagement by CO senior management to ensure consistency and alignment between these processes.
- **In addition to focusing on the core programmatic elements of a new approach, SURGE programme efforts could also have contributed to making a forceful and evidence-based case for resilience programming in advocacy with donors and other development partners (e.g. WB.** SURGE support could have included in this regard preparation of a strategic roadmap for UNDP advocacy, partnership-building, research and and programme development on resilience that would have more tightly integrated the various elements.
- **The programme strategy in the YRP was not considered by some to be innovative or radical enough.** Defining the scope of UNDP's new programmatic orientation entailed a delicate balance between building on the existing portfolio (with continuity and leveraging of existing know-how and resources) and doing something completely new (with the startup costs and risks associated with this). Some staff interviewed felt the pendulum swung too far to the former, focusing excessively on preserving existing projects while not sufficiently taking into account prevailing realities in the donor funding and operating environment.

Further, in the views of some, more innovative thinking was required on the approach to recovery and resilience, based on the recognition that 'conventional' early recovery approaches are not easily applicable in contexts of active conflict. This should have entailed analysis to identify relevant and realistic programming approaches and feasible implementation modalities, as well as more reflection on timing and sequencing of recovery efforts. From a thematic perspective, additional thought should have been given to approaches such as micro peace-building, credit to vulnerable communities, as well as interventions outside areas directly affected by conflict (which the DNA could have helped inform).

The SURGE team was also constrained by the lack of access to Yemen, which reduced their ability to adequately 'think through' and ground the strategy in the realities of Yemen. This was particularly in the case of the programmatic approach, which did not explain sufficiently how approaches to livelihoods and local governance would be tailored to the Yemeni context, as well as the implementation framework,

which was developed without a full understanding of the operating environment and the operational resources/capacities available in country.

Recommendations

1. In situations where a significant re-orientation of the country programme strategy is envisioned, or where there is uncertainty as to how needs and priorities could evolve, consideration should be given to development of a 'light' programme framework that can be adjusted over time, and emphasis placed on shorter-term interventions to respond to urgent needs and/or test new approaches.
2. Development of an overarching programme framework for crisis recovery should be balanced with the need to ensure rapid movement on design, financing and implementation of interventions in the short-term, including through the re-alignment of the existing programme portfolio. SURGE programme advisors should be fully integrated with the CO Programme team to ensure these processes are aligned. CRU Crisis Response Packages should constitute an essential part of the SURGE tool-kit in this respect.
3. SURGE support for programme development should be closely linked to CO advocacy, partnerships, RM and inter-agency efforts to facilitate a more strategic and comprehensive approach, and ensure that these different elements are mutual reinforcing.
4. In humanitarian contexts, UNDP programmatic support (including over the short-term) should build on a clear value proposition on UNDP's role in linking humanitarian and development needs, should be grounded in a close analysis and understanding of country realities and context, and informed by the priorities/plans of other international partners and UNDP's comparative advantage.

3.5 Operational response

This section examines the operational component of the response in terms of its ability to identify key priorities for strengthening UNDP's ability to deliver in timely and effective fashion in a challenging and volatile environment, both for the short-term response as well as organizational re-alignment of UNDP. Key issues reviewed include:

- Ability to identify and prioritize support to critical operational functions based on identification of a) implementation / delivery needs related to the crisis response; and b) existing operational bottlenecks and constraints;
- Quality, timeliness and effectiveness of assistance provided through the SURGE plan, including for the crisis response and broader CO operations;
- Sustainability of assistance provided through SURGE on operational issues / ability of CO to mainstream and integrate new operational mechanisms and modalities.
- Application of fast-track procedures: application, implementation and sustainability.

Main Developments

- **CO operations capacities were heavily impacted by the crisis in March 2015, beginning with the evacuation and relocation of international and national staff**, which left the CO essentially with a 'skeleton crew' to run operations and provide services. In the initial period, most CO operations effort was focused on processing payments for evacuated and relocated staff, servicing the DTF (Diplomatic Transit Facility) and struggling to pay vendors for services and goods in an extremely challenging environment. At the same time, a number of pre-existing operations bottlenecks and issues posed important impediments to a swift re-orientation of CO operations including:

- Lack of internal controls and system for delegation of authority
 - Internal organizational stove-piping and lack of communication (in particular between programme and operations teams)
 - Lack of crisis experience and expertise among operations staff
 - Mixing of funds (Core, XB, DPC) complicated financial sustainability planning due to uncertainty over which staff posts were linked to which funding source.
- The SURGE Operations team (two advisors who were fielded sequentially) provided a range of services to the CO, which overall was deemed valuable and have contributed significantly to improving operations capacities. Many of the procedures and systems developed with support from the Operations advisors appear to still be in use. these included:
 - Developing internal control and delegation of authority systems (still partially in use by CO)
 - Developing proposals for the establishment of a Programme Support Unit (PSU) to better integrate CO programme and operations functions (not taken up by CO);
 - Development of remote management guidance and SOPs, including on outsourcing of third party monitoring and NGO implementation modalities (in use by CO);
 - Provision of capacity development training for CO staff, delivered in Sana'a;
 - Development of guidance and SOPs on UNDP Fast Track procedures, adapted for the Yemen context (in use by CO)
 - Development of an organizational and staffing structure for the CO.

Findings

- **Operational support to the CO was a major priority that in hindsight could have merited more (and earlier) dedicated focus and resources as part of the overall crisis response and the SURGE deployment.** In the views of some, CO needs in the areas of operations were underestimated, and resulted in an imbalance, with far more focus and resources being dedicated to the programme response. In the views of some, a longer-term capacity development approach for operations should have been considered, which may or may not have exceeded the mandate of SURGE support. In the case of the former, some form of linkage could have been considered between short-term SURGE support for operations (which could have included more emphasis on HR, procurement and finance) and the more structural corporate backstopping and support provided through a subsequent change management effort.
- **An assessment of the CO's operations capacity undertaken prior to the March 2015 crisis would have enabled a more strategic formulation and targeting of support within the SURGE and broader corporate response framework.** By the time the SURGE team deployed, it was deemed too late to undertake such an assessment, as there was simply not enough resources and staff to spare for such an exercise. Such an assessment could have been undertaken as part of a more systemic approach for crisis preparedness, and ideally should have been implemented as of September 2014, when signs of a deteriorating situation became evident in Yemen. This links to the notion of a 'crisis' change management process invoked as part of UNDP's corporate crisis response.
- **On staffing, a number of colleagues have pointed to a tendency to preserve programmes and staffing structures in order to accommodate existing posts and staff.** While this is understandable in a crisis context—abruptly terminating staff due to project or organizational re-alignment in the middle of a crisis raises a host of issues—this did create the risk of compromising UNDP's ability to effectively re-orient itself, and created a significant financial burden for the CO (who used funds that could otherwise have been used to seed finance new projects). Placing this issue squarely on the senior management agenda – at the level of the CB and CO—could have facilitated identification of solutions, including for

instance the provision of temporary salary guarantees or assisted placement for affected staff, thus providing the flexibility to reshape programmes and the CO's structure as required.

Recommendations

1. As part of 'pre-crisis' corporate engagement and support, a rapid assessment of CO operational capacities should be undertaken to identify critical capacity gaps and provide a basis for identifying both SURGE support priorities and informing longer-term change management strategies.
2. SURGE supported provided as part of UNDP's crisis response should not be considered a substitute for a broader change management or capacity strengthening effort. In contexts where capacity needs are significant, SURGE support for operations should be complemented and linked to provision of additional corporate support organized through the regional bureau. This should ideally be assessed during the SURGE phase and included as part of SURGE transition and handover phase.
3. Re-orientation of CO programmes should be clearly delinked from staffing and contractual consideration. Staff on positions identified for termination should be supported as best as possible to allow them to transition with minimum disruption, including through temporary salary guarantees and corporately assisted placement in positions elsewhere in the organization.
4. On staffing more broadly, UNDP's crisis response SOPs should provide scenario-based guidance on how to address evacuation and reprofiling issues, which could help decrease potential delays and complications related to decision-making, and provide the basis for HR planning as part of a broader crisis response effort. These could also be integrated into business continuity planning.

3.6 UN and inter-agency coordination

This section examines the positioning of UNDP within the broader humanitarian and UN response for Yemen, in terms of both its support to coordination and leadership of the ER cluster, and its positioning as a key actor in its own right in implementing critical (early recovery) programming. Key issues reviewed included:

- Timeliness and effectiveness of UNDP engagement and leadership role in development and management of collective international and UN responses to the crisis;
- UNDP support for UN system coordination (RC/HC function);
- UNDP role in bridging humanitarian/development approaches;
- Facilitation and support for partnership building with donors and international actors.

Main Developments

- **The 'hard swing' to a full humanitarian response following the crisis in March 2015 was accompanied by a strong focus on emergency life-saving assistance and a reluctance to consider early recovery or resilience programming on the grounds that this focus in a situation of active conflict 'was too early'.** The implication of this was that the UNDP and other development agencies, because their activities were not deemed life-saving in nature, were not accorded high priority. The main consequences of this were the according of very few slots for UNDP international personnel (3-4), and the lack of space for dialogue and coordination on early recovery approaches. Furthermore, most humanitarian agencies were not inclined to work with the government in exile, favoring relations with actors on the ground to obtain humanitarian space. This overall situation was further exacerbated by the split in the RC and HC functions, until their eventual unification with the appointment of the Jamie McGoldrick as RC/HC in December 2015.
- **The reluctance to invest in early recovery and resilience was also evident among donors, but there were outliers.** Many donors, most of whom evacuated from Sana'a, refocused their programmes to

support humanitarian priorities. There were however some outliers like the European Union and the World Bank, both of whom maintained interest and focus in a recovery and development agenda.

- **Nonetheless, the Early Recovery cluster (which was established as part of the humanitarian cluster system in 2009) was maintained, but operated with limited engagement and support from other UN agencies and the donor community.** SURGE support contributed to the re-activation of the ER cluster and the mine action working group, coordination of the inter-cluster coordination mechanism, and reformulation of the cluster strategy. UNDP through SURGE support contributed directly to the development of the 2016 HRP.
- **Through SURGE support UNDP played a leadership role in the Yemen Damage Needs Assessment (DNA) through deployment of a Senior UN Coordinator.** The DNA was undertaken between August 2015 and May 2016. Although additional support for inter-agency coordination on recovery was envisioned as part of the SURGE plan (through the deployment of an Early Recovery Advisor), and recommended during the SURGE review mission in February 2016, this was not taken up by the CO Senior Management.

Findings

Humanitarian – recovery continuum

- **In view of the split between the RC and HC functions, and the disconnect and marginalization of the early recovery agenda this created, UNDP should have been more vocal in advocating for adherence to IASC humanitarian principles and commitments in this respect.** As reflected in the IASC OPR of January 2016, the six month time lag between the L3 declaration and unification of the RC/HC/DO functions was excessive (IASC guidelines call for unification of functions within 48 hours). Given this delay, and the impact it had on UN system coordination and a coherent humanitarian-development approach, UNDP's engagement and advocacy on ER issues at inter-agency level could have benefited from higher level corporate-level engagement, including at the level of the Administrator.
- **The RC in his dual capacity as RR, ensures that UNDP plays its role both in support of UNDG coordination and in facilitating thinking, dialogue and action on recovery.** With hindsight, stronger advocacy and engagement could have helped UNDP position itself more effectively and quickly in the collective thinking and dialogue on recovery and resilience that began to emerge during 2015 in the context of numerous donor consultations and processes such as the Damage and Needs Assessment.
- **More pro-active outreach with agencies and the broader UN system on resilience and recovery issues.** In the views of some staff, UNDP could have done more to generate a broader system-wide constituency on these issues, both within the ER cluster, but also in events such as the Dead Sea and Larnaca consultations, to which some feel greater UN agency participation could have been encouraged. Corporate-level outreach to other agencies might also have been beneficial in this respect.

Early Recovery

- **UNDP's support to the early recovery cluster could have been strengthened to more forcefully advocate on ER issues and engage in meaningful outreach with other UN agencies and donors.** Deployment of a more senior advisor on ER could have been useful in countering initial hostility from some UN agencies on the need for a ER, and building a stronger 'coalition of the interested' around ER priorities and programming. The decision not to deploy such an advisor – for which funds existed, according to the CRU – constitute an important missed opportunity.

Damage and Needs Assessment (DNA)

- **Even though the timing of the DNA was not considered appropriate (too early given on-going conflict) and politically sensitive (supported by the government in exile), it did present a platform for discussing recovery needs and priorities with ‘like-minded’ organizations (e.g. World Bank) and donors.** For this reason, UNDP could have benefited from according it a higher priority (indeed, some staff interviewed considered it a ‘distraction’), although this was not a simple matter given the range of other complex and urgent issues UNDP was attending to during that time period, and the political sensitivity of the exercise itself. A number of discussions and teleconferences held during the course of the DNA presented important opportunities to discuss broader recovery needs and approaches, which UNDP could have capitalized on.

Recommendations

1. At the onset of a complex crisis, and based on its situation assessment, UNDP should in future crises responses clearly highlight those early recovery, resilience and other developmental responses deemed critical as ‘non-negotiable’ based on IASC and WHS commitments, and be prepared to engage at the highest corporate level if necessary in this respect.
2. UNDP should explore multiple avenues to advocate, foster dialogue and secure consensus on recovery, resilience and other development priorities, including with the donor community, other development partners (including the World Bank and other IFIs), and national actors.
3. Within the UN system, UNDP should increase its support to the Resident Coordinator and inter-agency coordination mechanisms (including humanitarian cluster and recovery/development coordination fora) on recovery and resilience issues to facilitate evidence-based dialogue and consensus on UN system priorities and approaches.
4. UNDP should ensure robust engagement in both leading and contributing to Post-Disaster Needs Assessments (PDNAs) and Recovery and Peacebuilding Assessments (RPBAs), with a view to helping define a collective vision on recovery and development, build and strengthen partnerships with key development actors, and inform the positioning of UNDP’s programme strategy.
5. With respect to future DNA-type exercises (now known as Recovery and Peacebuilding Assessments, or RPBAs) in contexts of protracted conflict and crisis, emphasis should also be placed on iterative exercises that can provide a dynamic framework for assessing and costing needs and priority interventions as the situation evolves.

3.7 Communication and resource mobilization

This section examines the communication and resource mobilization component of the response in terms of its ability to improve UNDP’s strategic communication posture and capabilities nationally and internationally, and mobilize financial resources required to implement crisis response programming.

Main Developments

Communications

- SURGE Advisors supported the CO in undertaking an inventory on communications work in the CO, developing a communications strategy with clearance processes, and providing capacity development support to CO communications staff. In addition, the Advisors also supported the CO in preparing a number of stories and press releases and YRP communications.

Resource mobilization

- Following the crisis in March 2015, a two-pronged approach to resource mobilization was adopted. The first prong, which became the primary focus of CO senior management efforts throughout 2015, was the renegotiation of existing funding agreements with donors. The second prong was the mobilization of funding for new projects both within and outside the YRP framework, including resources mobilized in the context of the humanitarian flash appeal (from the King Salman Humanitarian Center and CERF).
- SURGE support for resource mobilization was provided at two levels: SURGE advisors supported the CO in developing a more systematic approach to resource mobilization, including through mapping of donors in Yemen, and development of a donor and funding tracker. Through SURGE support donor outreach was organized around the YRP, concept notes and proposals were prepared for donors, and key messages developed.
- During the Flash Appeal shortly following the crisis, UNDP developed 11 project proposals, 2 of which were financed by Saudi Arabia (on livelihoods and protection) and the CERF (mine action and waste management). This early period of resource mobilization helped strengthen relationships with Saudi Arabia, Netherlands, Japan and Sweden.

Findings

Communications

- **The deployment of a SURGE communications advisor in the second half of 2015 added value to the response** from the perspective of developing a coherent approach to strategic communications, strengthening communications capacity within the CO (through training of staff and development of guidance), and supporting advocacy and resource mobilization efforts. At the same time, it was clear that deployment of an advisor for a temporary period was not sufficient to sustainably enhance CO communications capacities, and as such SURGE support should not be considered a substitute for a dedicated capacity strengthening measures – particularly in contexts of protracted crisis.
- The experience of Yemen also highlights the importance of strengthening communications capacities earlier on as part of the crisis response, to ensure that CO staff receive adequate media and communications training.

Resource Mobilization

- **Support provided by the SURGE team on resource mobilization was considered by some in the CO as a ‘game changer’**, providing them with the capacity for a more structured approach involving systems for donor mapping and tracking and an organized approach to donor outreach.
- **At the same time, there was some confusion over responsibilities for preparing donor briefs between the SURGE RM advisors and CO programme staff, which led to duplication and lack of clarity.** This is linked to the disconnect between the two programming ‘tracks’ mentioned in the section on programmatic response, and could have been resolved by Senior Management instructions and guidance on responsibilities for RM.
- **A major handicap to strategic dialogue with donors and resource mobilization more broadly was the delay in finalizing the YRP.** Until then the use of shorter briefs and notes were useful in engaging donors, but not sufficient. This highlights the importance of setting clear and early deadlines for developing key programmatic objectives and reference documents for use in RM efforts (including concept notes and brief strategy/programme overviews). It also points to the need for greater rigor in setting and enforcing deadlines by which point important RM decisions need to be taken.

- **Given the challenges of engaging donors on resource mobilization at country level, greater support at corporate level was probably warranted.** Despite the establishment of an HQ-level Resource Mobilization Task Force for Yemen, which drew in colleagues from RBAS, BERA, CRU and others, this mechanism did not function, and RM issues were ultimately subsumed in regular meetings of the CMT. While HQ did support the organization of meetings with donors in New York and elsewhere, arguably these mechanism could have functioned better and been used to leverage a more structured and pro-active approach with donors, including through the various thematic and other fora in New York and donor capitals (Brussels, Tokyo).

Recommendations

1. Communications and resource mobilization constitute core functions that should be as a priority sustained following a SURGE mission, given the longer-term time horizons of related processes.
2. In contexts where re-alignment of programmes and donor funding are necessary, this should be considered as an integral part of the resource mobilization strategy, with a focus on engaging donors on dialogue to support new programmatic directions through reprogrammed and new resources.
3. Clear responsibilities and accountability for resource mobilization efforts should be defined at both the CO level (including between SURGE team and the CO) and between Regional Bureaus and BERA at the level of the CB/CMT. Deadlines for key RM deliverables and associated products (programme strategies, project documents, etc.) should be set and agreed upfront, and compliance monitoring through the CB – particularly in time sensitive contexts.
4. CO resource mobilization efforts should be supported by the Regional Bureau and BERA in contexts where country level donor presence is limited, and maximize use of relationships and dialogue platforms at HQ and in donor capitals.
5. Engagement on RM issues should be mandatory at the level of corporate mechanisms, either through regular meetings of the CMST or through a dedicated Resource and Mobilization Task Force, in situations of significant resource mobilization challenges. Discussions in these mechanisms should be overseen by the CB which should be responsible for monitoring progress and providing appropriate guidance.
6. Building on recent developments in strengthening partnerships between UNDP and the World Bank, consideration should be given to how partnership efforts can be broadened to other IFIs, including notably the IsDB, KfW, EIB, among others, with an emphasis on co-leveraging UNDP's in-country experience and operational and technical capacities with financing available from the former.

4. Concluding Observations

The crisis situation of March 2015 was characterized by both its slow-onset and protracted nature. The events of March 2015 marked a significant and extremely violent escalation of an existing crisis that had been deepening since late 2014. The impact of this new phase of the crisis (including increased armed conflict, civilian casualties, and destruction of property and infrastructure) was devastating and widespread. While its impact could not have been foreseen, developments in March were not, strictly speaking, a surprise, given the steady deterioration of the situation over preceding months. The second feature of the crisis was its protracted nature. During the time period covered by the AAR, there was no resolution to the crisis, which was marked by continued violence and insecurity for its duration, leading to a prolonged emergency response and predominantly humanitarian focus of international assistance.

The nature of this crisis had several important implications for UNDP's response, as framed by the Crisis Response SOPs. While noting applicability in slow-onset and protracted crises, the SOPs are primarily structured to enable a corporate response to a sudden crisis or disaster, with emphasis on enabling a swift

reorientation and strengthening of UNDP capacities in the immediate response period (3 months). This had two main implications for how the corporate response was developed and implemented in Yemen, which together make a case for further reflection on how the SOPs could integrate specific provisions for triggering, planning and implementing responses in the context of crises such as Yemen's.

First, the L2 corporate response was only triggered after the crisis escalated significantly in March 2015. While fully in line with the criteria of the SOPs, this did not take into account the fact that in Yemen—unlike natural disasters or situations of sudden crisis/conflict—there had been clear signs that the existing crisis was worsening. In the months leading up to the March 2015 several corporate crisis response options could have been considered, including an earlier triggering of the L2 or L3 phases, or a more concerted corporate focus and engagement during this phase to strengthen preparedness (including through an assessment of senior management, programme and operations capacities), strengthen early warning capacities, undertake contingency planning, and initiate pre-planning of support—prior to the formal activation of the corporate response.

Second, the Level 3 response focused on a strong temporary boost of expertise and resources, but did not adequately take into account the challenges to repositioning UNDP over the longer term. In Yemen, the protracted nature of the crisis meant that key conditions enabling UNDP engagement on recovery normally present in a 'post-crisis' context were either absent, delayed or complicated. These include the stabilization of the operating and security environment; re-establishment of national counterpart relationships (with government and other entities); mobilization around recovery and development priorities among national and international partners; and donor engagement on recovery/development issues. Almost none of these conditions were present during the time of the SURGE deployment due to the continuation of conflict, insecurity and a humanitarian-donor response focused almost exclusively on emergency life-saving assistance. Developing and implementing a UNDP recovery approach in this context was extremely challenging, requiring a more sustained and longer-term approach. While the SURGE deployment provided essential support to the CO, and in many ways laid the foundation for developments on programming, operations and RM that occurred in late 2016, the foregoing points to the importance of considering a more staggered or phased approach to SURGE support in protracted crisis situation that is calibrated to an analysis of the operational environment and realistic timelines for responding.

The case of Yemen also highlights the importance of corporate engagement in ensuring a strategic and integrated approach to positioning UNDP at the intersection of humanitarian, peace and development efforts. The predominantly life-saving focus on humanitarian assistance following the March 2015 crisis, and the institutional dysfunctionalities created by the split in the RC and HC functions, created significant challenges in generating momentum on early recovery and resilience priorities, positioning UNDP and mobilizing needed resources. With hindsight, a stronger and more forceful push on these issues was likely warranted, leveraging corporate positioning, partnerships and support, as well as a more strategic effort to integrate programme development, resource mobilization, inter-agency coordination and communications around the dual objectives of a) facilitating dialogue and building constituencies with key partners on the rationale and priorities for early recovery and resilience; and b) articulating and positioning UNDP's programmatic strategy as part of a broader vision and consensus on approaches to recovery and resilience.

Planning of SURGE support in the context of a severe and prolonged crisis warrants careful planning and consultation. Although the urgency of crisis situations requires swift action, the 'rush to deployment' can in certain cases be counter-productive if not carefully planned and adequately consulted. In Yemen, the large SURGE team deployed during the latter half of 2015 faced important challenges which constrained its overall effectiveness. With UNDP in-country presence limited due to insecurity, most of the SURGE team was obliged to support the CO remotely from Amman, severely limiting its ability to interact and collaborate effectively with CO staff, and develop sufficiently contextualized advice and support. Some SURGE functions, terms of reference and advisor profiles were not adequately consulted before deployment, leading to confusion and lack of clarity. Finally, little flexibility was demonstrated in considering modalities other than the deployment of international advisors, which might have been more effective given the constraint (for instance provision of seed funding for pilot initiatives and recruitment of national experts and service providers). In contexts of slow-onset and protracted crises there is some latitude for a more detailed SURGE

planning process, including more in-depth assessment of priority needs, definition of modalities for support tailored to the operational environment, and a properly structured process of consultation with stakeholders at HQ, regional and CO levels.

A related point is the linkage between SURGE support and other corporate change management and support functions. In the context of slow-onset and protracted crises – and particularly in cases where CO capacities are insufficient – SURGE support should not be considered a substitute for deeper ‘root and branch’ strengthening. SURGE support is –and should remain – focused on immediate response priorities and support, with the aim of rapidly providing expertise, resources and capacity to enable UNDP to scale its capacity and strategically reposition itself in a crisis situation. At the same time, this cannot be sustained in the absence of broader organizational change and strengthening, particularly in contexts such as Yemen, where every part of the CO’s capacity was affected by the crisis and had to be substantially refocused and retooled. Key to ensuring an effective and sustainable response lies in linking SURGE response to other corporate support functions and processes within the broader umbrella of the crisis response – and preferably as part of an integral strategy developed and overseen by the CB.

The case of Yemen also illustrates a number of challenges and trade-offs inherent in developing an appropriate programmatic response. The scale of the crisis in 2015 drastically and fundamentally altered the situation in the country, and necessitated a wholesale re-orientation of UNDP’s country programme. Re-engineering an active country programme portfolio is an immensely challenging task, and in the context of Yemen this necessitated developing an overall strategy early on in the crisis response (framed as either an ‘interim’ CPD or amendment to an existing CPD) predicated on recovery priorities and approaches deemed relevant and feasible in the prevailing context, and against which UNDP could bring to bear demonstrated comparative advantages. Such a strategy (even in most basic form) would provide the framework for revising existing projects and developing new ones. Integrating programme portfolio review and development within a single programme strategy, and using that framework as UNDP’s entry point in dialogue with other partners and donors on responding to the Yemen crisis, is arguably the way UNDP should have sought to position itself and engage with donors on both mobilization of new funds and reprogramming of existing resources.

Two significant opportunities were missed that could have led to a more effective programme response. The first, simply put, is that the Yemen Resilience Programme took far too long to be finalized – leaving UNDP without a clear (public) argument for a recovery approach and ‘offer’ to donors. Secondly, the process of developing the YRP and the review of the country programme portfolio were not adequately linked and were managed independently of each other, ultimately raising questions as to what exactly UNDP’s country programme strategy was. Key lessons learned include a) the importance of rapidly developing a basic overall country programme strategy as early on as possible in the response (and not overengineering it); and b) ensuring, through effective management, that programme strategy and portfolio review are fully integrated into a single process, ideally overseen by the SURGE Team Leader and DCD/P.

In the final instance, the CO and UNDP as a whole did benefit from the corporate crisis response. The corporate crisis structure demonstrated once again its value in providing a framework for communication, coordination and management across UNDP, and ensuring timely provision of advice and support to the CO. The SURGE assistance provided through the corporate response provided an array of critical services which in many respects provided critical capacity and expertise to the CO when it needed it the most (the challenging transition period following the 2015 crisis). Notable achievements in this regard include the development of a coherent programmatic vision and backbone for UNDP’s engagement, development of RM systems and support for donor outreach, establishment of a strategic communications capacity within the CO, and provision of support in operations which provided the CO critical capacity and know-how in operating in crisis context. The impact of the SURGE and broader corporate crisis response were not immediately evident, but in many ways are considered to have laid the foundations for the increase in donor funding, partnerships and CO delivery that took place from mid-2016.

Annex I: References

UNDP Crisis Response Documents

UNDP Yemen Crisis Board Meetings

- Meeting Minutes (July 9 & 30, 10 August, 15 December 2015; 12 April 2016)
- *Note to the Associate Administrator as a Follow-up to the Yemen Crisis Board*, 4 January 2016
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Yemen SURGE Documents

- *Plan in Response to the Yemen Crisis*. UNDP SURGE Planning Team, 6 August 2015
- *Terms of Reference*. SURGE Planning Team Yemen, July 2015
- *Support provided by the SURGE Team to the Yemen Country Office in 2016*. Stephen Kinloch Pichat, SURGE Team Leader, 31 December 2015
- *Review Mission of the Yemen SURGE Plan Implementation*. UNDP Mission Report, March 2016
- *Partnerships and Resource Mobilization Strategy*. SURGE Team, March 2016
- *Communications Handover Note*, SURGE Team, 2016
- *Draft Communication Plan*, SURGE Team, December 2015
- *Communications Strategy for Yemen*, SURGE Team, September 2015

Yemen Resilience Programme

- *Yemen Resilience Programme*. UNDP Yemen, 17 December 2015
- *Yemen Resilience Programme – Summary*. UNDP Yemen, January 2016
- *YRP Peacebuilding and Social Cohesion Brief*. UNDP Yemen, 2016
- *YRP Public Service Delivery Brief*. UNDP Yemen, 2016
- *YRP Public Economic Self-Reliance Brief*. UNDP Yemen, 2016
- *YRP Funding Tracker*, SURGE Team, September 2015

Elsadig, Abusabeeb. *Mission Report Summary, 6 July-5 August, 2015*. SURGE Mission Back to Office Report, 5 August 2015

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Von Huff, Charles. *Mission Report Summary: Yemen, 2-30 June 2015*. Mission Report Summary, 2 July 2015

UNDP Corporate Documents

UNDP Crisis Response SOPs

- *Standard Operating Procedures for Immediate Crisis Response*, Edition 16, November 2012
- *Standard Operating Procedures for Immediate Crisis Response*, version 2, April 2013
- *Corporate Standard Operating Procedures for Immediate Crisis Response*, Draft Version 3.0, April 2016

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UNDP Yemen Documents

Management Note on CO Transformation in Yemen. UNDP Yemen, 1 December 2012

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Country Programme Document for Yemen (2012-2015). Executive Board of the UNDP, the UNFPA, and UNOPS. DP/DCP/Yem/2, 12 July 2011

Forno, Short and Grundy. *Yemen Emergency Waste Assessment*. UNDP, August 2015

UNDP Household Survey Findings Report. UNDP Yemen, October 2015

Outline for a Rapid Integrated Assessment of Impact of Yemen Crisis. UNDP Yemen, 19 August 2015

UN Yemen Documents

Hadi Jadallah, Abdul. *Conflict Assessment of the Republic of Yemen*. UN Country Team Yemen, June 2015

Yemen Bridging Framework, 2016-2018 (Draft). UN Country Team Yemen, 22 January 2017

Documents related to Yemen humanitarian response

Teleconference on Yemen – Final Summary Note. IASC Emergency Directors Group, 24 June 2015

Yemen L3 Activation Discussion Background Note (draft). United Nations, 15 June 2015

IASC Operational Peer Review : Response to the Yemen Crisis. UN Inter-Agency Standing Committee, 26 January 2016

Flash Appeal for Yemen (1 April – 30 June 2015). UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (UN-OCHA), 17 April 2015

2015 Yemen Humanitarian Response Plan (Revised). UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (UN-OCHA), June 2015

2016 Yemen Humanitarian Response Plan (Revised). UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (UN-OCHA), January 2016

Other documents related to Yemen

Final Report of the Consultative Meeting for Yemen held in Larnaca, 6-8 October 2015. UN, World Bank, EU, November 2015

Yemen: Preliminary Damage and Needs Assessment. World Bank, UN, IsDB, EU, 11 May 2016

Annex II: AAR Terms of Reference

TERMS OF REFERENCE CONSULTANT AFTER ACTION REVIEW OF THE RESPONSE TO THE YEMEN CRISIS

DUTY STATION – HOME BASED + travel to New York and Amman

LANGUAGES REQUIRED – ENGLISH

STARTING DATE – February 2017

EXPECTED DURATION OF ASSIGNMENT – 25 WORKING DAYS

BACKGROUND ON THE CRISIS IN YEMEN

The current turmoil in Yemen can be traced to the country's political transition which was triggered by demands for democracy amidst the wave of demonstrations that dominated the Arab world in 2011. A transition agreement brokered by the Gulf Cooperation Council in November 2011 ended President Ali Abdullah Saleh's 33 years rule and spelled out a road map for a two years political transition dominated by a National Dialogue Conference under the supervision of newly elected President Abderabu Hadi Mansour (elected in February 2012). At the completion of the transitional period, a new constitution would be adopted and a new president would be elected.

The historical National Dialogue Conference (NDC) convened 565 representatives from the broad range of political, economic and social groups to tackle the most important and contentious issues facing Yemen through dialogue between March 2013 and January 2014. The NDC outcomes reflected recommendations emanating from the discussions of twelve working groups on critical social, political and economic issues that country needed to address. One of those outcomes was a draft constitution containing a controversial six region federal state proposal, which highly displeased the Southerners and the Northerners. This was exacerbated by a number of developments (including the decrease of energy subsidies) whereby the Government of Yemen was perceived not to have delivered on its promises and to Yemeni's expectations in an inclusive manner. Riding on the wave of growing public discontent against the transitional government, the Houthis in alliance with ex-President Saleh seized the capital Sana'a in September 2014 and took de facto control over state institutions through their political wing Ansar Allah. Despite the signing of the UN-brokered Peace and National Partnership Agreement by all political parties and the Houthis, the implementation was limited to the establishment of a new technocrat cabinet in November 2014 led by Khaled Bahah. The later started operating in exile from Riyadh, when Saudi Arabia hosted President Hadi and his government in March 2015.

Following the escalation of the conflict with the intervention of the Saudi-led coalition in March 2015, the UN was evacuated to Amman in Jordan, and was only able to come back with a limited number of staff in May 2015. UNDP Yemen has been operating with a back office in Amman since then with a small number of staff members allowed to Sana'a on rotation basis.

In July 2015, UNDP deployed a SURGE planning mission to Amman to work with the country office on scaling up its capacities to respond to the deteriorating humanitarian and development crisis unfolding in Yemen. The SURGE Plan for Yemen was finalized in August 2015 and implemented from August 2015 to March 2016. Following this, a SURGE review mission took place in February 2016 and recommended a number of follow up actions

OBJECTIVE AND SCOPE OF THE AAR

The objective of the After Action Review (AAR) is to examine the performance of UNDP with respect to the response to the crisis in Yemen, and highlight lessons learned that would help strengthen the functioning, performance and efficiency of UNDP response to protracted conflicts, including: UNDPs corporate and country level programmatic and operational response; UN and interagency coordination; contribution to Disaster Needs Assessment (DNA) and recovery processes. The AAR will also draw recommendations for future crisis response situations.

The AAR will address the following:

Overall Response

- Analyse the corporate stance prior to the activation of the L3 Crisis Board;
- Examine the UNDP's response in the context of an L3 crisis with special emphasis on compliance with crisis response systems and processes (before the finalization of the draft corporate SoPs) at global, regional and country level. This includes i) timeliness and effectiveness of strategic decisions and actions by decision makers and other key stakeholders in the organization in order to respond to the crisis; ii) internal communication and coordination flows within UNDP to support the CO's efforts to respond to the crisis; iii) timeliness and effectiveness to quickly scale up UNDP Yemen's capacity to undertake immediate crisis response activities and set the course for UNDP engagement in recovery, resilience building activities in the face of a protracted crisis.
- Review UNDP's overall preparedness for crisis response [CO, regional, global] including the decision-making processes and their efficiency in the context of corporate response - with the view to inform the finalization of the SOPs for UNDP's immediate crisis response.
- Examine UNDP's ability to take on a "whole of UNDP" approach to the response and recovery efforts;
- Assess how UNDP technical and programmatic expertise was leveraged during the crisis response;

Programmatic Response

- Review the pertinence of UNDP's recovery programme formulation and the choices that were made in terms of programme priorities; the reasons why those choices were made; and overall programmatic performance;
- Examine whether adjustments were made to the existing country programme in response to the crisis (including the identification of new programmes);
- Draw lessons on the sustainability of UNDP programmatic activities and function performed by SURGE Advisors and positioning in response of the crisis;
- Examine the role SURGE Advisors played in programme development and implementation, programme realignment and resource mobilization;
- Provide an analysis on the added value provided by the SURGE Advisors in the elaboration and delivery of programmes at the country level;
- Examine the collaboration between the experts deployed under the SURGE modality and the programmatic staff in country, at global level and in the Regional Hub;
- Look at whether the response was in line with the commitments of the WHS in terms of bridging the humanitarian development divide

Operational Response

- Review the timeliness and effectiveness of the overall operational response, and the application of the SOPs and decision-making processes. This part of the review will focus on country, regional and HQ level responses, in addition to the interaction between these dimensions of the response;
- Review the efficiency and effectiveness of immediate crisis response standard operating procedures, as well as analyze their application in the context of the response. This includes but is not limited to the application of Fast Track procedures and rapid response processes (financing, deployments, recruitment, procurement, etc.);
- Review the relevance and timeliness of the SURGE work plan, and quality of SURGE deployments, including when relevant of UNDP Stand-by partners, and management of SURGE advisors in country;

- Examine the operational bottlenecks and constraints faced by the CO in terms of both operations and programme implementation;

UN and Interagency Coordination:

The effectiveness and adequacy of UNDP's engagement with the broader humanitarian action. Including a review of:

- a) The extent of UNDP's coordination and cooperation with key humanitarian partners on the ground;
- b) UNDP's leadership of the Early Recovery Cluster on the ground in supporting recovery and UNDP capacity to attract partners and resources to the cluster;
- c) Clarity of UNDP's role and actions vis-à-vis other partners, including but not limited to other clusters, IFIs, and NGOs;
- d) UNDP's ability to link immediate early recovery to longer term recovery efforts;
- e) UNDP's ability to build synergies and mainstream the recovery agenda in the needs assessment processes (such as MIRA and DNA) and humanitarian funding instruments;
- f) Support on Early Recovery to the Humanitarian Coordinator and the Humanitarian Country Team.

Communication and Resource Mobilization:

- Examine the timeliness and effectiveness of communication, including relationship with media, and resource mobilization efforts;
- Review UNDP's level of success in mobilizing funds from humanitarian funding sources, including but not limited to Flash Appeal and CERF Rapid Response Grant.
- Capacity to mobilize resources taking into account the outcomes of the WHS.
- Examine internal and external factors that impacted donor funding decisions, identifying areas for improvement.
- Assess donor response to the UNDP programme, identifying gaps and areas for improvement;
- Assess donor response to the overall ER agenda and UNDP leadership of the ER cluster;

DELIVERABLES

The review will cover UNDP's response to the crisis in Yemen and will focus on August 2015 to March 2016, which corresponds to the SURGE plan implementation period. The review cover UNDP HQ, Regional Hub in Amman and the Yemen Country Office as well as all aspects of UNDPs response and its role in the interagency arenas.

The recommendations will have a forward-looking view, with aim to identifying best practices and innovations that can be systematized, particularly conflict triggered crisis that tend to adopt a protracted nature, as well as practices that need to be avoided in the future. It will also define areas for further investment and improvement in the response. In addition the ARR will provide:

- A work plan with methodology and timeline for the AAR exercise based on the elements outlines in the objective and scope section of the ToR that will be prioritized with UNDP;
- A timeline with an overview of facts and events;
- An overview of key recommendations implemented / not implemented from past AARs;

- An inception report on the initial findings to be delivered prior to the Country visits (if possible), and regional hub visit;
- A draft report on best practices, lessons learned and recommendations, focusing on key issues as highlighted in the objectives above;
- A forward looking Action Plan for implementing recommendations with a focus on operationalizing the new corporate SOP for immediate crisis response and relevant UNDP crisis response packages, and UNDP's role in transcending the humanitarian-development divide in a post-conflict context;
- A final report on best practices, lessons learned and recommendations, focusing on key issues as highlighted in the objectives above;
- A two pager document summarizing the key findings and recommendations of the AAR exercise;
- A debriefing meeting in New York as well as a multi-stakeholder sharing of the findings and recommendations, such as a presentation to key UNDP stakeholders from UNDP Yemen, Amman and New York.

METHODOLOGY, TIMELINES AND TRAVEL

An independent consultant will be recruited to conduct the after action review. He/she will report to the Crisis Response Unit (CRU) Rapid Response and Preparedness Team who will oversee the day-to-day management of the team, with support from the Crisis Coordination Team (Asia Pacific, Arab States and ECIS) and the Regional Bureau for Arab States (RBAS). The final report will be presented to RBAP and CRU for final endorsement.

Timeline for the review will be February - April 2017.

Information will be gathered from primary and secondary sources. This includes desk reviews, key informant interviews in headquarters with central and regional bureaus involved, the country office and deployed personnel. Meetings with partners and stakeholders, field visits, focus group meetings with stakeholders and surveys.

DESCRIPTION OF RESPONSIBILITIES –

Under the direct supervision of the Program Specialist (CRU Rapid Response and Preparedness Team), and in coordination with CRU Crisis Coordination Team (Asia Pacific, Arab States and ECIS) as well as RBAS, the consultant for the AAR exercise will:

1. Lead the AAR exercise from preparation to final delivery in close collaboration with CRU, RBAS and the Country Office.
2. Lead the development of questionnaire, methodology, mission schedule and work plan for the AAR.
3. Gather and review all the necessary documents related to the Global, Regional and Country level response, including relevant procedures and practices.
4. Draft an inception report on initial findings, including an overview of recommendations implemented / not implemented from past AARs, and an overview of the facts and events.
5. Lead the consultations processes related to the AAR, including preparatory meetings, surveys, in country visit in UNDP's back office in Amman, focus group discussions, debriefings and final report presentation by liaising and coordinating with all relevant stakeholders.
6. Lead an analysis on key processes/mechanisms (ERA, ERCC, SURGE planning) conducted during the response.

7. Produce a draft AAR report, compile and address comments that arise from the draft report internal circulation.
8. Produce a final and consolidated AAR report, a two pager document summarizing the key findings and recommendations, as well as a forward looking Action Plan for implementing recommendations for submission to the UNDP CRU and RBAS.
9. Facilitate a multi- stakeholder sharing of the findings and recommendations.

COMPETENCIES –

Core Competencies:

Ethics & Values:

- Demonstrating / Safeguarding Ethics and Integrity;
- Demonstrates and promotes the highest standard of integrity, impartiality, fairness and incorruptibility in all matters affecting his/her work and status.

Functional Competencies:

Organizational Awareness:

- Demonstrate corporate knowledge and sound judgment understands the structure and hierarchy of UN/UNDP, process flows throughout the organization, products and services, their measures of effectiveness, and perceptions of clients;
- Excellent knowledge of humanitarian and recovery issues and internationally-agreed humanitarian and recovery standards;

Working in Teams:

- Acting as a team player and facilitating team work;
- Works collaboratively with colleagues inside UN/UNDP as well as its partners and other stakeholders to pursue common goals.

Communicating Information and Ideas:

- Facilitating and encouraging open communication in the team, communicating effectively;
- Delivers verbal/written information in a timely, clear, organized and easily understood manner;
- Excellent oral and written skills to develop knowledge products in relevant areas;
- Strong communication skills and the ability to listen and take direction and leadership from others.

Self-Management & Emotional Intelligence:

- Creating synergies through self-control tolerates conditions of stress, uncertainty or ambiguity and continues to maintain a positive outlook and to work productively.

Knowledge Sharing & Continuous Learning:

- Ability to efficiently handle and share information and knowledge.

Functional competencies:

- Knowledge of emergency preparedness and response, including early recovery policies, and inter-agency mechanisms;
- Ability to adopt and apply methodology and tools for After Action Reviews (AAR) in emergency and crisis situations;

Excellent drafting and report writing skills.

QUALIFICATIONS –**Education:**

- Advanced University degree (Master's Degree or equivalent) International Relations and/or Regional Studies, Project Management, Human Resources or Information Technology.

Experience:

- At least 10 years of professional experience providing advisory support and technical advice in the area of emergency and crisis response and recovery.
- Experience in conducting After Action Reviews (AAR) for emergency and humanitarian response, particularly in conflict triggered crisis contexts. Proven record of producing AAR reports an asset.
- Experience in emergency preparedness and response planning, reporting and coordination;
- Exposure or relevant experience to develop and/or manage knowledge management systems and capacity development exercises;
- Field experience in emergency response in conflict crisis contexts and preparedness is an asset;
- Proven ability to work under pressure with quick turnaround deadlines, and to deliver in a timely manner within cost and quality standards;
- Computer proficient and well versed in the use of Microsoft Office and other relevant Internet, Excel and Word;
- Proven ability to work in a multicultural setting.

Language:

- Proficiency in English is a must, knowledge of Arabic an advantage;
- Proficiency in Arabic would be an added advantage.

PAYMENT PROCEDURES-

Payments under this contract will be delivery-based with the various installments being processed upon receipt of key deliverables, as follow:

Deliverables	Estimated Duration Complete ⁷ to	Percentage of full payment
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⁷ Not binding, for consultant consideration only. The payment will be delivery based only.

• Draft methodology and work plan • Initial data collection and consultations (online) with UNDP Yemen and the Regional Hub in Amman, and (online or in person) with UNDP New York; • A timeline with an overview of facts and events; • An inception report on the initial findings from the desk review;	5 days	1st installment: 20% of full payment
• A visit to the UNDP Yemen back office and to the UNDP Regional Hub in Amman to collect relevant data for the AAR, conduct focus group discussions and stakeholders interviews • A draft report on best practices, lessons learned and recommendations, focusing on key issues as highlighted in the objectives section of the ToR; • A forward looking Action Plan for implementing recommendations with a focus on operationalizing the new corporate SOP for immediate crisis response and relevant UNDP crisis response packages, and UNDP's role in transcending the humanitarian-development divide in a post-disaster context;	15 days	2nd installment: 50% of full payment
• A final report on best practices, lessons learned and recommendations, focusing on key issues as highlighted in the objectives of the ToR; • A two pager document summarizing the key findings and recommendations of the AAR exercise; • A debriefing meeting in New York as well as a multi-stakeholder sharing of the findings and recommendations, such as a presentation to key UNDP stakeholders from UNDP Yemen, Amman and New York.	5 days	3rd installment: 30% of full payment

Annex III: UNDP Staff Interviewed

	Name	Title	Bureau
1	Mourad Wahba	Director	RBAS
2	Sophie de Caen	Deputy Director	RBAS
3	Celine Moyroud	Program Advisor	RBAS
4	Edwine Carrie	Program Specialist	RBAS
5	Bruno Lemarquis	Deputy Director	CRU
6	Stephen Kinloch Pichat	SURGE Planning Team, SURGE Advisor D/CD	a.i. CRU
7	Asmaa Shalabi	Program Specialist, Arab States focal point	CRU
8	Bettina Woll	Crisis Coordinator, Asia Pacific, Arab States and Europe and CIS	CRU
9	Paolo Lembo,	Yemen RR/RC (former)	
10	Jamie Mcgoldrick,	Yemen RR/RC/HC (current)	
11	Auke Lootsma	Country Director (current)	UNDP Yemen
12	Mikiko Tanaka	Country Director (former)	UNDP Yemen
13	Edward Christow	Head of Governance Unit	UNDP Yemen
14	Federica Dispenza	Early Recovery Cluster Coordinator	UNDP Yemen
15	Tareq Gholasi	Operations Analyst	UNDP Yemen
16	Abdo Seif	Program Advisor	UNDP Yemen
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21	Jerome Sauvage	Operations Adviser	SURGE
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24	Sylvain Merlen	Head of Aden Sub-Office	UNDP Yemen
25	Arwa Ahmed Humaid	Donor relations assistant	UNDP Yemen
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27	Malin Herwig	Policy Specialist	RBAS RH
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31	Harald Bredesen	RM Adviser	SURGE
32	Rossana Dudziak	Team leader	BPPS
33	Luc Vandamme	Director, Security Office	BMS
34	Henrietta De Beer	Chief, Human Resources Policies & Compensation	OHR/BMS